

ALEXANDER WATSON

Counselling

- 1 I know exactly why I do this.
- 2 I know exactly why I do this.
- 3 I know exactly why I do this.

Practice Clarity & Identity

What the practice stands for, who it is for, how it sounds and what it looks like – decided once, so the ordinary business of running a practice doesn't reopen it.

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Internal. Not for publication

Written while Alexander is in training. Nothing here may be used to offer sessions until the facts on page 16 are confirmed and the practice is permitted to open. It contains no qualification, registration, membership, insurance, fee, address, availability or outcome that has not been supplied – where one is needed, it is marked to *confirm*.

About this guide

A practice written down before a website is designed for it.

The website is one expression of this practice. This guide is the practice: what it stands for, who it is written for, how it sounds and what it looks like. Whatever gets made next – a leaflet, a directory profile, a sign, a second site – starts from here rather than from the last thing made.

How it is arranged

- 01 **Before the practice.** The central idea, the candidates it was chosen over, and a test against the twelve themes you supplied.
- 02 **Part One · The practice.** What is true about the work, the people it is written for, what it is and is not, and what is still unknown.
- 03 **Part Two · The words.** The position, four descriptions, the order messages go in, and a voice specific enough to write something new in five years.
- 04 **Part Three · Visual identity.** Derived only after the first two were settled. Your supplied logo artwork, one typeface, nine colours with one job each, and the one visual idea.
- 05 **Part Four · In use.** A brief that holds in any medium, then the website as one implementation of it, then print, rooms and suppliers.
- 06 **Part Five · Keeping it.** Checks, an asset register and the rules for change.
- 07 **A–D and the tests.** The five decisions everything depends on, what is least certain, the questions only you can answer, a creative brief, and the eight quality tests you asked for – with their results, including where the identity only partly passes.

Three kinds of statement

Established Something you told us. Your training, your placement, your themes, your supplied logos.

Interpretation Something derived from what you told us. The central idea, the reader, the voice. You are entitled to say it is wrong.

Recommendation A creative or strategic decision. Colour, type, structure. Each has a reason; if the reason is wrong, so is the decision.

Each section opens with a line saying which of the three it mostly is.

What this document is not

It is not public copy, and Part One and pages A–D are never sent to a supplier. They contain more about you than a client should ever read, because the identity had to be derived from you. For every personal fact the test was: *does knowing this help a prospective client understand what it would be like to work with Alexander?* Where the answer was no, the fact shaped a decision and stayed out of the content.

It is not a claim about your competence. Nothing in it describes what you are qualified to do.

Every decision here should lead back to the idea on page 05. If one doesn't, take it out.

The rule the rest of the guide is held to

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If you only read four pages

Page 05 (the idea), page 18 (the position), page 22 (the voice) and page 58 (the five decisions).

If someone is making something from this

Page 47 is the brief. Page 53 says which pages and files each trade needs. No page assumes the reader has seen a website.

Finding the central idea

Nine candidates. Most of them are true, and most of them lose.

You asked for the idea underneath your twelve themes, not one of your phrases. Each candidate was tested for three things: does it hold all twelve, does it belong to you rather than to the category, and could it go wrong in the hands of a counsellor who believed it too much.

Basis: interpretation

Candidate	What it gets right	Why it isn't the organising idea
Accuracy before reassurance	Your strongest instinct, and the right register for the voice.	It is a manner, not a subject. It also belongs to Sofia Marin, whose identity statement is almost exactly this. Your own practice can't be organised around a portfolio case you wrote.
Noticing rather than fixing	Describes what you actually do in the room, and protects autonomy.	Describes the method, not what the method is for. It is also the territory you gave Helen Calder. Kept as the professional identity, page 07.
The distance between knowing and doing	The most recognisable to a reader. It is the hook.	It names the symptom without explaining it, invites the promise to close the gap, and is already a management-book phrase. Kept as the position, page 18.
Capacity, not character	Distinctive and humane. Explains the shame loop.	Too narrow to organise a practice; it would drift towards a burnout specialism you haven't claimed. Kept as a belief and as the design principle.
Two things can both be true	Holds your contradictions without pathologising them.	Generic (it is the most common line in therapy content), passive, and its visual consequence is the two-part mark the studio has already made too many times.
The person under the performance	Masking, social performance, exhaustion.	Sofia's territory again, and it implies there is a truer self to uncover – exactly the claim you distrust.
The stories that make behaviour make sense	Good on the explanations people build around other people.	Puts the counsellor in the role of editor of someone's story. Too close to interpretation-as-authority.
Understanding what a behaviour protects	Explains avoidance, fear of success, masking, independence and shame in one move.	Very close. But "protect" implies a defence to be dismantled, and it can't hold capacity: tiredness isn't protecting anything. It is one of the answers, not the question.
Nothing repeats for no reason	Chosen. It holds all twelve (page 05), it is plain English, it asks a question instead of supplying an answer, and it sits squarely in both traditions you trained in. Its failure mode is known and is written into the philosophy: not everything is a pattern.	

A finding worth stating plainly

Your portfolio has already spent several of your own traits. Precision went to Sofia, noticing without deciding to Helen, plain speaking to Daniel, permission to Maya. An identity built from your supplied phrases would have failed the swap test against your own work. The idea chosen is the one none of them owns: **repetition, and what it is doing**.

How it was tested

Against the twelve themes, the portfolio, the client experience you asked for, and the likeliest misuse: a counsellor who treats every difficulty as a pattern to decode. The last of these is why the idea carries a limit.

The central idea

- 1 Nothing repeats for no reason.
- 2 Nothing repeats for no reason.
- 3 **Nothing repeats for no reason.**

What keeps happening in a life is usually doing something – avoiding a failure or a success, keeping someone at a workable distance, saving energy that isn't there. That is why understanding it so often doesn't change it: the explanation arrives, and the job it was doing still needs doing. The practice exists to find out, without a verdict and at the person's pace, what it is doing and what it costs. What they do about it stays theirs. And the reason is usually more ordinary than the story told about it.

Basis: interpretation of your twelve themes · the organising idea · said in public once, in the three hundred words

#	Your theme	How the idea holds it
01	Accuracy before reassurance	An accurate account of what something is doing. Sometimes the accurate account is that the situation is hard and nothing needs decoding.
02	Noticing rather than fixing	The reason is found by noticing, and handed back. The idea never tells the counsellor to remove the repeat.
03	Understanding is not change	Its central claim: knowing the story isn't the same as the job being finished.
04	Success and failure	Not acting repeats because it protects from both outcomes at once.
05	Capacity	Some repeats have the plainest reason of all: there isn't enough in the tank. Reading that as character is the mistake.
06	Shame	The shame loop is a repeat with a reason – shame makes the task heavier, which feeds the avoidance.
07	Masking and performance	The acceptable version keeps being produced because it has kept something safe. It also costs.
08	Autonomy	A reason found together is not a verdict delivered. The person decides what, if anything, changes.
09	Relationships	Closeness and distance repeat across relationships. The stories told about other people repeat too.
10	Contradiction	Two real needs are often the reason. The repeat serves one of them at the other's expense.
11	Not a problem to solve	A repeat with a reason is a person making sense, not a person who is broken.
12	Directness	It is five plain words. It needs no vocabulary to be understood.

Where it comes from in your training

Psychodynamic thinking has long held that what isn't understood tends to be repeated, and that it shows up again in the relationship with the counsellor. Person-centred thinking locates much distress in the gap between experience and the "shoulds" a person has absorbed. The idea is both, said in plain English. That matters for the five-year test: it will still be true after you qualify.

Its limit, written in from the start

Not everything is a pattern. Caring for someone, losing someone, a relationship ending: sometimes the accurate response is *yes, that is hard*, and the work is staying with it. The issues you describe from your placement – bereavement, responsibility, changed circumstances – are often exactly this. A practice that decoded grief as a pattern would be using its idea as a hammer.

01

Practice at a glance

One person, one question, and most of the facts still to come.

Basis: established where stated · interpretation for the concern and the feeling

The practitioner	The people	The central concern	What a client should feel
Alexander Watson, in Greater Manchester. Training in therapeutic counselling – person-centred and psychodynamic – with a Level 4 Diploma at Stockport College due for completion in 2027. Currently on placement, in supervision and in personal therapy.	Adults (<i>age range to confirm</i>) who can describe what keeps happening in their lives – sometimes very well – and find that describing it hasn't been enough. Also adults carrying something that is simply hard, who would rather it was called that.	What keeps happening, and what it is doing. Avoidance, closeness and distance, the “should” that outruns capacity, the version of yourself that is easier to show. Understanding before intervention.	Spoken to as an intelligent adult. Recognised without being diagnosed. Free to look properly before deciding anything, and in no doubt that the decision is theirs.
The practical facts		Why this page comes first	
Name	Alexander Watson	Everything after this page comes from these four columns. A colour, a sentence or a photograph that can't be connected to one of them has no reason to exist.	
Descriptor	Counselling		
Status today	Trainee counsellor – Level 4 Diploma in Therapeutic Counselling, Stockport College, completing 2027	The ledger is mostly blank on purpose. The identity has been built so that every blank has a place waiting for it – and so that nothing in the identity depends on a fact that hasn't been decided. The status line in particular is kept out of the logo, the position and the descriptions, because it is the one fact certain to change.	
Status on opening	<i>To confirm, in the exact wording your awarding and membership bodies permit</i>		
Where	<i>To confirm – Stockport has been suggested; no address is established</i>		
Online	<i>To confirm, including whether it is offered as equal to in person</i>		
Fee and session length	<i>To confirm</i>		
Days and times	<i>To confirm</i>		
First step	<i>To confirm – whether there is a first conversation, how long, and whether it is free</i>		
Reply time	<i>To confirm</i>		

Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why.

The position, page 18 · the one sentence that appears wherever there is room for one

02

Professional identity

More interested in what something is doing than in what it says about you.

Six characteristics that hold across everything the practice does and says. They are descriptions of how you already think and work, written down so they can be repeated and checked.

Basis: interpretation of your stated themes

Asks what it is doing

Before a behaviour is treated as a flaw, it is treated as information. The first question about anything that keeps happening is what it is for, and the second is what it costs.

Says the plain true thing

Including *that is hard* and *I don't know* yet. Accuracy is offered as a form of respect. It is never used as permission to be harsh.

Notices, then hands it back

Observations are offered to be checked, and withdrawn if they are wrong. What the person does with any of it stays theirs. Nobody's life is redesigned in the room.

Keeps two things in view

Wanting closeness and wanting to be left alone; loving someone and resenting what it asks. Both can be real, and neither has to win early. Contradiction is usually where the work starts.

Reads capacity before character

A task that isn't getting done is first a question about what is left in the tank. *I should be able to do this* is examined, not obeyed.

Notices what is missing

The gap in a story, the difference between how something is presented and how it is lived. Your design work trained this habit. It shapes the attention and is mentioned once, plainly, if at all.

What the characteristics leave out, on purpose

Warm, empathic, non-judgemental, compassionate. They are all things a counsellor should be, and all things every counsellor says. Written as adjectives they are claims. The characteristics above describe behaviour that a client can check, which is where warmth actually shows.

How your other work is used

Your design and writing background explains the attention to language, contradiction and presentation. It is context. It does not appear as a selling point, a visual theme or a metaphor for therapy, and the counselling practice never shows design work.

A counsellor more interested in what a pattern is doing than in what it seems to say about the person.

Identity statement · the one sentence to keep, internal

03

Philosophy of practice

Knowing why isn't the same as being free of it.

This is the belief the practice runs on. If it is wrong, most of what follows changes – the reader, the position, the voice and the visual idea were all derived from it.

Basis: interpretation · to be checked against your own view before anything else

- 01 **Things repeat because they work – at something.** Not acting protects against failing and against succeeding. Keeping a distance protects against being left. The acceptable version of yourself protects a place in the group. Each of these has a cost, which is usually why the person has come.
- 02 **Insight is necessary and rarely enough.** A person can understand their history, their attachments and their fears in detail and carry on as before, because the explanation doesn't do the job the repeat was doing. That gap is not a failure of intelligence or effort.
- 03 **Capacity is not character.** Reading limited capacity as a moral failure creates shame, and shame makes the next task heavier. Decisions made while depleted are rarely the ones a person would make otherwise.
- 04 **Two needs can both be real.** The work doesn't require choosing between them early, and the contradiction is not a symptom.
- 05 **The person is the authority on their own life.** The counsellor's job is to notice and say, and to be corrected. The person decides what, if anything, to do.
- 06 **Not everything is a pattern.** Some things are simply hard, and the accurate response is to say so and stay with it.

Where it sits in your training

The first and second beliefs are psychodynamic in origin; the third and fifth are person-centred. None of them needs its vocabulary to be understood, and the practice never uses the vocabulary to sound serious.

What it deliberately doesn't believe

That there is a true self waiting under the performed one. That a person arrives broken. That understanding guarantees change, or that change always means doing less of something.

03

Philosophy of practice – what follows from it

A belief is only useful if it changes what you do.

Each belief has a consequence in the room and a consequence in anything the practice publishes. If a consequence can't be seen, the belief isn't doing anything.

Basis: recommendation

Belief	In the room	In anything published
Things repeat because they work	The first curiosity is about function. <i>What does this do for you?</i> comes before <i>why can't you stop?</i>	Behaviour is described without a verdict. No “self-sabotage”, no “procrastination”, no “bad habits”.
Insight is rarely enough	Explanations are welcome and not treated as the finish line. What happens in the relationship itself is taken seriously.	The position speaks directly to people who already understand. Nothing promises that understanding will fix anything.
Capacity is not character	Pace follows capacity. Nobody is asked to make a large decision in a bad week.	Everything is readable on a bad day – short, plain, findable. This becomes the design principle, page 30.
Two needs can both be real	Contradictions are held, not resolved on the person's behalf.	“And” where two things are true. No either/or framing, no “finally choose yourself”.
The person is the authority	Observations are checked. Being told <i>that's wrong</i> is useful information.	No advice, no instructions, no telling a reader what they feel. The first step is small and can be undone.
Not everything is a pattern	Grief, caring and endings are met as they are. Nothing is decoded that doesn't need to be.	Situations that are simply hard are named alongside the repeating ones, so the practice doesn't read as a pattern clinic.

The ordinary reason

The idea can drift towards mystery – a hidden cause, a deep wound, an inner child. The practice keeps it ordinary. Most reasons are plain: tiredness, a fear that was once sensible, a habit that used to help, a relationship that needs something to stay the same. Saying so is part of what makes the practice feel adult rather than mystical.

The hammer problem

A counsellor who likes an idea will find it everywhere. The check is simple: when a client brings something, ask first whether it is repeating at all. If it isn't, the idea has nothing to say, and the practice shouldn't pretend otherwise. Supervision is the right place to test this, and it is worth naming there.

The reason is usually more ordinary than the story told about it.

The guard against mysticism · usable in public copy

04

The people the practice speaks to

Can explain it. Still doing it.

This sets who the writing speaks to most directly. It is emphasis, not a clinical boundary and not a limit on who you see. It starts from a situation and a relationship to that situation, not from demographics.

Basis: interpretation, with your assumption challenged on the next page

What shows from outside

Coping. Often the capable one, the person others rely on. Work gets done, or mostly. From outside there is little to worry about, and they have become good at keeping it that way.

What keeps happening

The same argument. The thing that doesn't get started. The relationship that ends the way the last one did. Saying yes, then resenting it. Being fine in company and flat afterwards.

What they have already tried

Thinking about it, a great deal. Often reading, podcasts, sometimes previous therapy. Plans made on good days that assumed the good days would last. Being harder on themselves.

What they want from this

To understand it in a way that actually changes their relationship to it. To be told the truth. To make decisions from what they have, not from what they think they should have.

What they are wary of

- **Being handled.** They notice technique, and reassurance delivered in advance reads as a method.
- **Being told what they feel.** Especially by a page that has never met them.
- **Being labelled.** By a condition, a type or an attachment style. Some already carry more labels than they asked for.
- **Being cheered on.** *You're doing amazingly* feels like being managed.
- **Being out of their depth in a commitment.** Signing up to something they can't undo when their capacity drops.

So the writing

- Describes situations and behaviour, and names no feeling on the reader's behalf.
- Uses ordinary sentences people actually say, which a reader either recognises or doesn't.
- Names no conditions and no client types. There is no "who I work with" list.
- Puts the facts where a sceptical reader looks for them, before anything is asked of them.
- Makes the first step small, clear and reversible, and says so.

A note on emphasis. Writing for this reader excludes nobody. It decides the tie-break: where a sentence has to choose whom it speaks to, it chooses this reader – and the people for whom something is simply hard are written for alongside them, never as an afterthought.

04

The people – your assumption, challenged

Your description of the client is right about a part of the audience, and wrong as its definition.

You suggested people who function well, think a lot, have consumed psychology content, understand themselves intellectually and stay stuck. Three problems with making that the definition.

Basis: interpretation · the most important challenge in Part One

It is a portrait of you	It rewards the defence	It misses your placement
Most of the description matches how you describe yourself. Practitioners who write for their own reflection attract people who resemble them, and then find those are the clients they are least able to see clearly. It is a known risk, and a supervision conversation rather than a design one.	A site that flatters cleverness attracts people who hope to think their way out, and gives them an intellectual sparring partner. For some of them, intellectualising is the very thing that keeps the pattern in place. The practice shouldn't advertise itself as a better conversation about the problem.	The issues you describe from placement – bereavement, resentment, responsibility, changed circumstances – belong to people who may have no psychology vocabulary at all and still understand their situation perfectly well, without that helping. They belong to this audience, and the definition would have written them out.

The coherent audience, restated

People who can see what keeps happening, and for whom seeing it hasn't been enough – whatever their education, vocabulary or experience of therapy. Alongside them, people carrying something that is simply hard, who would rather it was named accurately than made to sound better.

Three readers inside that audience		Who the writing is not aimed at
The one who can explain it	Knows the history and the theory. Still doing it. Your supplied reader, kept, but no longer the whole.	This is a communication priority, never a clinical exclusion. The writing makes it easy to see quickly that this may not be the right fit for: – Someone wanting a structured, technique-led course with set exercises. That exists, it helps many people, and a kind pointer elsewhere is better than a vague welcome. – Someone who needs urgent or crisis support. The practice is not an emergency service and says so on every page. – Someone looking for a diagnosis or an assessment. – Anyone whose needs fall outside what you and your supervisor agree you are trained for. That line is decided with your supervisor and is never published as a list of conditions.
The one whose "should" outruns them	Reads every limit as a character flaw. Shame loop. Often very capable.	
The one carrying something real	Caring, loss, a relationship ending, a life that changed shape. Wants the difficulty acknowledged, not explained.	

On neurodivergence. Masking and performance are treated as a wider human idea, as you asked. The practice makes no neurodivergence-specific claim and uses no neurodivergence-coded language or imagery. Whether any personal experience of yours is ever mentioned is yours to decide; nothing in this identity depends on it.

05

What the practice is, and is not

Clear enough that someone can rule you out in a minute.

A practice that tries to suit everyone suits nobody in particular. Being specific about what happens and what doesn't saves two people time – the one it suits and the one it doesn't.

Basis: interpretation of your themes · every “do” and “don't” to be confirmed as true of your practice

What the practice is

- One-to-one counselling, with one person, for adults (*to confirm*).
- Talk-based and open-ended in content: sessions follow what the person brings rather than a programme.
- Grounded in person-centred and psychodynamic thinking, described in plain English.
- Interested in what keeps happening and what it is doing, and equally willing to stay with what is simply hard.
- A regular arrangement with clear terms (*frequency, length and terms to confirm*).

What you do

- Listen for what repeats – in what is said, and in what happens between you.
- Say what you notice, plainly, including when it is awkward.
- Check whether you have got it right, and change your mind when you haven't.
- Ask the question that matters, one at a time.
- Say when you don't know.
- Stay with something difficult without hurrying it towards better.
- Keep to the arrangement, so the hour is dependable.

What it is not

- Coaching, advice or a plan for someone's life.
- A structured, skills-based course with homework by default.
- Assessment or diagnosis.
- A crisis or out-of-hours service.
- A specialist service for any condition or group.
- A conversation about design or websites. The studio never enters the room.

What you don't do

- Diagnose, or imply a diagnosis.
- Tell someone what to do with their life.
- Tell someone how they feel, or that you know how they feel.
- Praise attendance as bravery.
- Interpret everything. Some things are what they look like.
- Pursue someone who has decided not to continue (*recommended; confirm as policy*).
- Offer sessions before the practice is permitted to open.

Why “homework by default” and not “never”. Your themes say nothing about between-session tasks, and some clients will ask for them. The practice doesn't impose them; it can agree to them. If that is wrong, change this line and the “what it is not” line together.

05

What the practice will not claim

Every claim here is one a client could check, and the rest are left out.

You asked for this list explicitly. It is written as a table of the category's usual claim, the true thing underneath it, and what the practice says instead – so it works as an instruction, not a list of refusals.

Basis: established (your ethics) and recommendation

The usual claim	Why it isn't made	What is said instead, where anything is needed
Qualified, accredited, registered, specialist, expert, psychotherapist	None is established. Several can only be used with a professional body's permission.	The status line, exactly as permitted at the time. Today: <i>Trainee counsellor</i> .
Understanding will help you change	It often doesn't. That is the practice's whole premise.	What keeps happening can be looked at properly. What changes, if anything, is the person's to decide.
I know exactly how you feel	You don't, and it is partly why they are coming.	Nothing. The practice describes what it does, not what the reader feels.
A safe, non-judgemental space	"Safe" is a promise no one can keep on someone else's behalf.	What stays confidential and its limits, including supervision; a dependable arrangement; that you aren't there to decide whether they are a good person.
You've taken the first brave step	Reading a web page isn't brave, and saying so is handling.	How to get in touch, and what happens next.
Years of experience, specialisms, client outcomes, testimonials	Not established. Asking clients for testimonials also sits badly with their confidentiality and your relationship with them.	Your training, stated factually. Nothing about results.
Counselling is right for everyone	It isn't, and a structured approach suits some people better.	A plain line saying what kind of work this is, and a pointer for people wanting something else.

What the practice asks of a client

- To say when something you've said is wrong. People are polite about this, and it slows everything down.
- To keep to the arrangement, and to say if it stops working (*terms to confirm*).
- Nothing else in advance. No need to know what the problem is, or to explain it well.

What the practice cannot serve

Emergencies, out-of-hours contact, and anything needing urgent medical care or a kind of help you aren't trained to give. This is stated wherever someone might be about to rely on it, with plain signposting to urgent help beside it. Any physical access limits of the room will be stated the same way once the room is known.

A limit is stated at full size, in the first person, before anyone has to look for it.

The rule this page sets

06

The experience a client should have

Seven pairs. The first half of each is easy; the second half is the job.

These are the experiences you asked for. Each becomes a requirement with a named way of meeting it and a named way of breaking it, so it can be checked on anything the practice makes.

Basis: established (your list) · recommendation (how it is met)

The experience	Met by	Broken by
Recognition without being diagnosed	Ordinary sentences and situations a reader either recognises or doesn't. The repeat device, page 26.	Condition lists. "Do you suffer from...?" Checklists of signs.
Warmth without being handled	Attention shown through specifics: exact facts, real answers, a reply that addresses what was actually written.	"You deserve...", "you're not alone", exclamation marks, first names used as reassurance.
Depth without mysticism	Ordinary reasons. The two traditions named once, plainly, where it helps.	Inner child, energy, soul, journey, anything implying a hidden truth only you can see.
Professional without institutional coldness	Complete facts, in the first person, in the order someone needs them.	"Service users", "please note that", policy language, passive voice about fees.
Direct without aggression	The true sentence, then the decision handed back.	"You need to...", "the truth is...", provocation for effect, challenge as a style.
Structure without rigidity	A clear arrangement – time, length, notice – around sessions whose content follows the person.	A named method with steps. "My six-stage process."
Space without emptiness	Less on each surface, and every space next to something useful.	A large blank first screen with a vague sentence in it.

The sentence you gave the site to communicate

"You don't need to convince me that your problem is serious enough."

Said directly, it tells the reader what they were worried about.
Expressed instead as two plain lines, placed where they are needed:

How it is expressed

It doesn't need to be serious, and you don't need to explain it well.

Beside the contact form.

There's no threshold. If something keeps happening and you'd like to look at it properly, that's reason enough.

In "How I work".

06

The experience – the sequence

Someone should be able to inspect you fully before they decide anything.

The sequence below applies to any first contact, whatever the medium. It is built on two of your ideas: that acting creates the possibility of both failure and success, so the first step must be small; and that decisions shouldn't be made while depleted, so nothing is urgent.

Basis: recommendation

- 01 **Look.** Everything needed to judge fit is available without contact: who you are, how you work, what it costs, where, and what you don't do. Nothing is gated behind a call.
- 02 **Recognise, or not.** A few ordinary situations and sentences. The reader either sees something of their own or learns quickly that this isn't for them. Both are useful outcomes.
- 03 **Check the facts.** The practical ledger appears early and again at the end. Numbers are exact. Blanks are never filled with "get in touch to find out".
- 04 **Decide, in their own time.** No countdowns, no "limited spaces", no pop-ups. Leaving and coming back next month is expected.
- 05 **Write.** A short message. Only a name and a way to reply are required. The box for anything else says a sentence is plenty.
- 06 **Hear back, plainly.** A reply within a stated time (*to confirm*) that answers what was asked, confirms the practical facts and offers one clear next step. If you aren't the right person, it says so and suggests where to look.
- 07 **Change their mind, freely.** If someone doesn't reply, they aren't chased (*recommended; confirm as policy*). The door stays open without being pushed.
- 08 **Arrive.** They know which door, what the room looks like, and what the first session is for (*details to confirm*). Online, they know what they will see on the screen.

What is never done to hurry this

Urgency, scarcity, a free-gift download, a newsletter sign-up, an automated follow-up sequence, a chatbot, a booking widget that asks for a reason before a time. Each makes the first step bigger than it needs to be.

The test for anything new

Does it make the first step smaller, or bigger?

If bigger, it needs a reason stronger than convenience.

07

Still to be confirmed

Deliberately left blank.

Nothing below has been assumed. Each item has a place already waiting in the identity. Until you supply it, it appears nowhere – inventing any of it would be dishonest, and several would be a professional risk.

Basis: established · this page is a checklist

Professional standing		Practice operations	
Qualification wording	Exactly as your course and awarding body permit, before and after completion	Location	Town, room, address and when the address is shared
Membership and register	Body, category, number, and the wording they permit	Access	Steps, lift, toilet, parking, public transport
Insurance	Insurer and cover, if stated	Online	Platform, whether equal to in person, UK-only or wider
Supervision	How you describe it publicly, if at all	Fee and session length	Including any reduced fee and how it is offered
Personal therapy	Whether it is mentioned. Recommended: no, or only as a training requirement	Days and times	And whether there is a waiting list
Placement	Whether Trafford Carers Centre may be named, with their permission	First step	Conversation or not; length; free or not; phone or video
Scope of practice	Agreed with your supervisor. Never published as a condition list	Payment and cancellation	Method, timing, notice period
Age range and frequency	This guide assumes adults and regular sessions	Reply time	And the days you reply
Complaints route	Where a client goes if it isn't you	Data and notes	ICO registration, what is kept and for how long
Opening date	When the practice may take private clients	Domain and live site	alexanderwatsoncounselling.co.uk is linked from the studio site. Check today what it says: if it invites clients, change it before anything else

Five that change the words as well as the facts

- 01 **Whether the studio is mentioned.** Recommended: one plain sentence in About, no link. It changes the About page and page 33.
- 02 **Whether there is a free first conversation.** It changes key message 06 and every call to action.
- 03 **In person, online, or both as equals.** It changes the descriptor line, the photography and the signage pages.
- 04 **Whether “I won’t chase” is true.** It is a strong trust signal only if it is policy.
- 05 **Whether the carers placement is named.** It broadens the reader visibly, needs the centre’s permission, and must never read as a specialism.

07

Still to be confirmed – the status line, by stage

The one fact certain to change is kept in one place.

Your status will change at least twice. The identity is built so that each change edits one line and nothing else: the logo, the descriptor, the position and the descriptions don't mention it.

Basis: established (today) · to confirm (later stages)

Stage	Status line	What may exist publicly	What may not
Now in training, on placement	Trainee counsellor · Level 4 Diploma in Therapeutic Counselling, Stockport College, completing 2027	Nothing that offers sessions.	Any page, profile or card that invites private clients, or implies you are available.
On completion	<i>To confirm – the award, in your awarding body's wording, and any membership in its body's wording</i>	The website, directory profiles, cards – once insurance, data registration and a room are in place.	“Qualified” as an adjective of quality; any membership category not yet granted.
Later	<i>To confirm – registration, accreditation or further training, only when held</i>	An updated status line. Possibly a new descriptor if the work genuinely changes.	Years of practice as a claim of quality.

Where the status line appears

Website	Under the name in About; in the footer
Directory profiles	In the fields the directory provides
Business card	Reverse, smallest line
Email signature	Second line
Leaflet	Back page
Invoice	Footer

When it changes, change all six on the same day. Page 55 lists this as a check.

Where it never appears

- Inside the logo lockup.
- In the position or the four descriptions.
- As a headline, a badge or a strip of logos from professional bodies – unless a body requires its mark, and then at the smallest size it permits.
- As letters after the name on the wordmark.

A note on the word “counsellor”

It isn't a protected title in the UK, which is exactly why this guide treats it carefully. While you are in training, “trainee counsellor” is the accurate phrase and the only one used. The descriptor “Counselling” names the activity, so it stays true at every stage.

08

Position

One sentence, and what each part of it is doing.

The position is the sentence the practice commits to in public. It is how the central idea is met first; the idea itself is stated in public only once, at length, in the three hundred words.

Basis: recommendation

Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why.

The position · ten words · never reworded

What it claims

- **“Counselling”** – the activity, which stays true at every stage of your training. No status, no modality.
- **“What keeps happening”** – a subject, not a condition. It reaches people who don’t think of themselves as unwell, and it is how most people describe their own patterns before they have a word for them.
- **“Even when you know why”** – the recognition. It speaks directly to the reader who has already done the thinking, and the word “even” includes everyone who hasn’t.

What it deliberately doesn’t claim

- **An outcome.** Nothing says the gap will close. It names the situation and stops.
- **A population.** No age, group, identity or condition.
- **A method.** Person-centred and psychodynamic are explained where there is room, never used as a headline.
- **A feeling.** The “you” in it is about knowing, not feeling – the one second-person headline the practice allows itself, because it states a fact the reader can check.

The longer form, for anywhere that needs a paragraph

Counselling for adults in *[place] [and online]*, about what keeps happening – in relationships, at work, in how people treat themselves – including the things they already understand. The work is finding out what a pattern is doing and what it costs, without a verdict, and leaving what to do about it with the person. It makes equal room for what is simply hard.

Where space runs out

Beneath the name, where ten words won’t fit	The first five only: “for what keeps happening”. No other shortening.
On a sign or door	No position. Name and descriptor only.
In a directory headline	The full ten words.

The test

After one reading, can someone tell a friend what you work on, in words you would use?

If a new piece of writing needs the position rephrased to fit, the writing is wrong.

09

Descriptions at four lengths

Written once, so none of them has to be improvised.

Every form you will meet asks for one of these lengths. If a limit falls between two, shorten the longer one from the end – the first sentence is the one that must survive. Bracketed items are placeholders from page 16; nothing is published until they are filled.

Basis: recommendation · written for the practice as it will be once open

About twelve words · a card, a profile header, a sign-off

Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why. *[Place] [and online]*.

13 words: the position unchanged, then the place. Where only ten words fit, the position alone.

Forty words · a social biography, a short directory summary

I offer counselling in *[place] [and online]*. I work with adults on what keeps happening – in relationships, at work, in how they treat themselves – including what they already understand. *[Fee]* for *[length]*. No need to explain it well first.

39 words. “Offer counselling” names the activity, so it stays true whatever the status line on page 17 says.

One hundred words · a directory profile, a leaflet, an introduction

A lot of people can already explain a good deal about themselves. They know roughly where a pattern came from, what it costs and what would probably help. It keeps happening anyway. That isn’t a failure of intelligence or effort. Usually, whatever keeps happening is doing something – keeping a disappointment away, holding a distance, saving energy that isn’t there. Counselling with me is a place to work out what, without deciding in advance what it says about you. I’ll say what I notice. What you do with it is yours. *[Fee]* for *[length]*, in *[place] [and online]*.

97 words.

Why the hundred words open where they do

The first sentence is the recognition, stated as a general observation rather than a claim about the reader or about your clients. A reader who can explain themselves recognises it without being told; a reader who can’t isn’t excluded, because nothing says they must.

What is missing from all four, on purpose

Qualifications, memberships, years, specialisms, outcomes, “safe space”, and any list of what people come with. Directories will ask for several of these in separate fields. Fill those fields with facts from page 16 and leave the descriptions as they are.

09

Descriptions – three hundred words

An About page, or the longest profile a directory allows.

Basis: recommendation · every sentence to be checked by you for likeness

I offer counselling to adults in *[place]* *[and online]*.

A lot of people can explain a good deal about themselves. They know where a habit probably came from, what it's costing them and what would help. It keeps happening anyway – the conversation that doesn't get had, the work that doesn't get started, the relationship that goes the way the last one did. Knowing why isn't the same as being free of it, and that gap isn't a character flaw.

My view is that nothing repeats for no reason. Something that keeps happening is usually doing a job: avoiding a failure, or a success; keeping someone close enough, or far enough away; saving effort for a life that's already asking a lot. The work is finding out what, without anyone deciding in advance what it says about you.

Not everything is a pattern. Caring for someone, losing someone, a relationship ending – sometimes the accurate thing to say is that it's hard, and to stay with that rather than explain it.

In sessions I listen, and I say what I notice, including when it's awkward. I check whether I've got it right, and I'll tell you when I don't know. Sessions follow what you bring rather than a programme. I won't diagnose you or tell you what to do with your life. What you do with any of it stays yours.

My training is in person-centred and psychodynamic counselling. I also work as a designer, which has left me with a habit of noticing the difference between how something is presented and what it's actually like.

[Fee] for a *[length]* session. *[First step.]* It doesn't need to be serious, and you don't need to be able to explain it well before you write. Take whatever time you need to decide.

298 words, and the choices inside them

- **The central idea appears once**, here and nowhere shorter. "My view is" marks it as a view.
- **"Avoiding a failure, or a success"** names the less obvious half of avoidance, which most descriptions miss.
- **The "not everything is a pattern" paragraph** is what keeps carers, the bereaved and people in hard circumstances inside the audience.
- **Your design work gets one sentence**, and the sentence is about attention, not design. Delete it if you decide the studio isn't mentioned – nothing else depends on it.
- **No personal history.** None would help a reader judge what working with you is like. The status line sits beside this text, not inside it.
- **"Stays yours"** closes the method paragraph, so the last thing said about the work is about autonomy.

If a directory allows fewer words

Drop, in this order: the design-work sentence; the training sentence (the directory has a field for it); the second half of the "nothing repeats" paragraph. Never drop the "not everything is a pattern" paragraph.

10

Key messages, in order

Six things to say, and the order to say them in.

This reader inspects before feeling anything, so the order is: what this is, why it might be for them, what it asks, how it works, what it costs, and what happens next. The order matters more than the wording.

Basis: recommendation

- 01 **What this is.** Counselling, with Alexander Watson, for adults, in *[place]* *[and online]*. The status line close by. Stated before anything else is asked of the reader.
- 02 **The position.** Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why. Never omitted wherever there is room for one sentence.
- 03 **No threshold.** It doesn't need to be serious, and it doesn't need to be explained well. Said once, beside the action, in plain words.
- 04 **How it works.** I say what I notice; what you do with it is yours. Plus what doesn't happen: no diagnosis, no advice about your life.
- 05 **The facts.** Fee, length, when, where, how to start, how long a reply takes (*all to confirm*). Exact numbers in numerals.
- 06 **Your pace.** Looking first is expected. The first step is small, and changing your mind is fine.

How many to use

Never all six in a short piece. A card carries 01 and 02. A directory profile carries 01, 02, 04 and 05. A leaflet has room for all six. The website carries all six on the home page, briefly, and again at length.

The load-bearing one

04. The reader's main fear is being handled, and 04 is the only message that answers it by describing behaviour. If a piece of writing quietly contradicts it – by advising, reassuring in advance or telling the reader what they feel – it has undone the practice's central offer, whatever else it says.

What is never a message

Qualifications as a headline. Years as a claim of quality. A list of conditions. Bravery. A promise about how someone will feel afterwards. "Safe space". Any of these may appear as a fact; none is ever the point of a piece.

11

Voice – the principles

Plain, dry and attentive. An adult talking to an adult across a table.

Seven principles. They describe how you already speak when you are being careful, with the casualness taken down one notch and nothing else removed.

Basis: interpretation of your stated communication style

01 · Say the ordinary version

“It keeps happening”, not “recurring relational patterns”. If a clinical or theoretical word is needed, it is used once and explained in the same sentence.

03 · Allow the true, uncomfortable sentence

“That is hard.” “I don’t know yet.” “I might be wrong about this.” Short, unsoftened, and not followed by a silver lining.

05 · Keep both

Where two things are true, join them with “and”. “It makes sense, and it costs you.” Contradictions are stated, not resolved on the reader’s behalf.

07 · Dry, never jokey

Understatement is allowed, and so is a plain observation that happens to be funny. No puns, no wordplay in headings, no exclamation marks, and never humour at a reader’s expense or about anything a client brings.

02 · Describe behaviour, never feelings

Situations and actions a reader can recognise. The practice never names a feeling on someone’s behalf – not in a headline, not in a caption, not in a reply.

04 · Hand it back

Where a piece reaches a decision, the decision is the reader’s. Sentences end on their choice: “That’s your call.” “Whenever suits.”

06 · Short, then shorter

One idea to a sentence; three sentences to a paragraph at most. Readable by someone with very little left at the end of a day. This is the voice’s version of the design principle.

The sentence most likely to undo it

Reassurance in advance. Telling a reader it will be all right, that they are doing brilliantly or that they are brave – before anything is known about them – is the practice’s single most damaging sentence, because it is the one this reader has learned to distrust.

11

Voice – how sentences are built

Structure, rhythm and register, specifically enough to check.

Basis: recommendation

Sentence construction

- Subject first, verb early. “I say what I notice.”
- Active voice, first person. “I charge [fee]”, never “fees are charged”.
- Average around twelve words. Nothing over twenty-five without a very good reason.
- Concrete nouns over abstract ones. “The work that doesn’t get started”, not “procrastination”.
- Qualify honestly and once: “usually”, “often”, “in my view”. Never stack qualifiers.

Rhythm

- A longer explanatory sentence, then a short plain one. “It keeps happening anyway.”
- Lists of situations are allowed to run to four or five. Lists of qualities are not allowed at all.
- A page is skimmable in twenty seconds and still rewards a slow read.
- Silence is used: a short paragraph standing alone does more than an adjective.

Register

- Conversational in construction, careful in content.
- Contractions throughout – “don’t”, “isn’t”, “I’ll”.
- Never casual about the client’s material. Casual about the admin is fine: “It’s a form. Two boxes are required.”
- Where a sentence could be warm or exact, it is exact. Warmth comes from having paid attention.
- British spelling throughout.

The second person

Used freely for practical instruction and for plain statements about what the reader doesn’t need to do (“you don’t need to explain it well”). Used for knowledge, carefully (“even when you know why”). Never used for feelings, never three times running, and never in a “you might be feeling...” sentence.

Questions

One genuine question per piece at most, and only a question the reader might usefully ask themselves. Never rhetorical, never leading, never a list of “do you ever...?”. The device is on page 26.

Punctuation and figures

Dashes	Spaced en dashes – like this – for an aside. No em dashes.
Numbers	Numerals for money, time, duration and dates: 10am, 6.30pm. Words for small counts in prose.
Money	Whole pounds, no “00”. The session length always travels with the fee.
Case	Sentence case everywhere, including headings, buttons and labels.
Emphasis	By position and by the yellow attention mark, page 45. Italic only for words said aloud or quoted. No bold in running prose on the website.
Never	Exclamation marks, emoji, ellipses for suspense, arrows in text, ampersands in prose.

The same content, before and after the voice

Before

If you’re feeling stuck in unhelpful patterns, I offer a safe, non-judgemental space where we can explore what’s holding you back and empower you to move forward on your journey.

After

If something keeps happening and understanding it hasn’t been enough, we can look at what it’s doing and what it costs. What you do about it stays yours.

12

Words that fit, words to avoid

The practice already has a vocabulary. Most of it is ordinary.

The left column isn't a list of words to insert. It is the vocabulary the practice already thinks in, so a new sentence can be checked against it. The right column is barred, with the reason.

Basis: recommendation

Words and phrases that belong

keeps happening · again · the same way the subject, in the reader's words

what it's doing · what it costs the two questions

makes sense · for a reason · ordinary sense before verdict

notice · say · check · get it wrong what the work consists of

hard · difficult · a lot said plainly, not softened

and · both two things true at once

capacity · what's left · enough limits without shame

yours · your call · whenever suits the decision handed back

I don't know · I might be wrong · usually honest uncertainty

write to me · arrange · the next step what a reader is asked to do

counselling · sessions · regular the plain names for the service

pattern sparingly – "what keeps happening" first

Barred, with the reason

self-sabotage · procrastination · bad habits · lazy · unmotivated verdicts dressed as descriptions

struggling with · suffering from · living with assigns a condition and a feeling

overthinker · people-pleaser · imposter syndrome · high-functioning labels the reader will reject or cling to

attachment style · inner child · shadow work · nervous system regulation vocabulary as identity; several imply training you haven't claimed

trauma-informed · neurodivergent-affirming · specialist in claims of competence, not established

brave · courageous · you deserve · be kind to yourself tells the reader what they are or should do

I hear you · valid · you're not alone · reach out performed warmth

toxic · boundaries (as a slogan) · mindset · self-care content-platform language

client-centred · service user · intervention · presenting issue institutional register

qualified · accredited · registered · expert · psychotherapist unestablished status, until page 17 says otherwise

authentic · passionate · holistic · bespoke · unique adjectives that claim rather than describe

Constructions to watch for

"Not just X, but Y" manufactures emphasis. **"It's about..."** explains instead of describing. **"Whether you're X or Y..."** addresses everyone and names nobody. **"You might be feeling..."** tells the reader what they feel, politely. **"It's okay to..."** gives emotional permission nobody asked for.

Why "authentic" is barred twice over

It is a category cliché and implies a true self waiting underneath, which this practice doesn't believe. It is also in the name of another of your projects, Embracing Authenticity; keeping it out keeps the two apart.

12

Words – the category's phrases, translated

Where a cliché points at something real, say the real thing.

You asked that when one of these concepts genuinely matters, the idea is expressed without the phrase. Each row takes the phrase apart and keeps only what is true.

Basis: recommendation · the right-hand column is usable copy

Barred phrase	The idea underneath	How this practice says it, if at all
Safe and non-judgemental space	You can say things without being judged, and it stays private.	What you say is confidential, with limits I'll explain at the start – including that I discuss my work, anonymously, in supervision. I'm not there to decide whether you're a good person.
Your journey · healing journey	It takes time and isn't a straight line.	It rarely goes in a straight line, and it often takes a while.
Holding space	Staying with something difficult.	I can stay with something difficult without hurrying it towards better.
Navigate life's challenges	Specific situations.	Name them: a relationship that ends the same way each time; caring for someone; work that won't get started; a loss.
Become the best version of yourself · reach your full potential	Acting more in line with what you want. It is also the "should" this practice questions.	Nothing. If anything: some people want to act more in line with what they actually want. I can't promise that, and I won't measure you against a better version.
You don't have to face this alone	Another person's attention helps.	Some things are easier to look at with someone else there.
Take the first step · first courageous step	Getting in touch.	If you'd like to talk, write to me. It doesn't need to be serious, and you don't need to explain it well.
Authentic self	The gap between how you come across and how things are.	The difference between how things look from outside and how they actually are.
Empower · transform · unlock	Outcomes the counsellor causes.	What you do with it is yours. Things can change; sometimes what changes is how much it costs you.
You are brave · you deserve	Approval.	Nothing. Attention does this job better than approval.
I know exactly how you feel	Understanding.	Nothing. The practice demonstrates attention by answering what was actually said.

If the plain version sounds too small, the cliché was promising too much.

The rule behind the right-hand column

13

Recurring devices

Five moves the writing makes, again and again.

A voice is partly vocabulary and mostly structure. These are the structures, and they are portable – each works on a page, in an email, on a leaflet or in a directory.

Basis: recommendation

01 · The repeat

An ordinary sentence people actually say, set down three or four times, identically, and counted. The last one is marked. No meaning is supplied underneath – the reader supplies it, or doesn't. It is the central idea, shown rather than explained, and it becomes the visual idea on page 30.

Rules: the sentence names no feeling and no condition; never more than four repeats; never more than one per surface; if a caption is needed, one plain line.

- 1 It's easier if I just do it myself.
- 2 It's easier if I just do it myself.
- 3 It's easier if I just do it myself.

It keeps happening for a reason. Usually an ordinary one.

Other sentences that work

I'll sort it properly next week. · I'm fine, it's just a busy time. · I'll reply when I've got a proper answer. · It's not worth making a fuss about. · I know exactly why I do this.

02 · The plain acknowledgement

A short sentence that says something is hard, standing on its own. No "but", no silver lining, no next step in the same breath. *Caring for someone can be relentless.* The practice's answer to reassurance.

03 · The hand-back

End on the reader's decision. *What you do with it is yours. Whenever suits.* Used once per piece, at the point where a lesser practice would push.

04 · The honest limit

Say the thing you can't offer, or don't know, at full size. *I don't offer a set programme. If that's what you're after, [pointer] is a better place to start. I might be wrong about this.*

05 · The one real question

A single question a reader might usefully ask themselves, set on its own, with no answer. *What would it cost you if this stopped happening?* Never rhetorical, never a list, never "do you ever feel...?". At most once per piece; many pieces have none.

What is not a device. Lists of signs you might be experiencing. Rhetorical questions. Lists of three adjectives. Motivational closing lines. Quotations from famous therapists. Anything that names a feeling on the reader's behalf. These are the category's habits, and using one makes a piece sound like every other practice.

14

Voice by context – the website and directories

What changes between contexts is length and order. What never changes is the position, the refusal to diagnose, and the facts.

Basis: recommendation

The website

The one place with room for everything, so it is where the idea is shown rather than stated. Facts first, then the repeat, then situations, then how you work at length, then the practical section written as content. Everything shorter refers back to it.

Page headings say something: “Most of it is ordinary”, not “My approach”. Navigation stays plain. Buttons say what happens: “Write to me”, not “Get started”.

A therapist directory

A hostile format: a grid of photographs, a row of condition checkboxes and a paragraph competing with hundreds of others. Don’t adapt the voice to the directory’s house style – the contrast is what gets a profile read twice.

- Headline: the position, unchanged.
- Opening: the hundred words from page 19. If the directory truncates, move the last sentence (fee and place) to the front – the only change allowed.
- Checkboxes: tick only what is true and agreed with your supervisor. Fewer is better; a long list reads as a claim of competence in all of it.
- Approach fields: person-centred and psychodynamic, with one plain sentence each if the field allows.
- Photograph: the portrait, page 44. Nothing else.
- Status, membership and insurance fields: exactly as page 16 confirms.

Tone marker

Most people I work with can already explain a good deal about themselves. It keeps happening anyway.

Tone marker

Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why.

Plain sentences for approach fields

Person-centred: you are the authority on your own life, and my job is to understand it as you do.

Psychodynamic: what isn’t understood tends to repeat, including between us, and that can be looked at.

Practical information, in any context

Written in the first person, at full size, with the reason where there is one. The session length always travels with the fee. A limit is volunteered before it can be discovered. Nothing is “policy”.

Example, if you charge for late cancellation – complete with confirmed terms

Sessions are *[fee]* for *[length]* minutes, paid by *[method]*. If you cancel with *[notice]* or more, there’s no charge. With less, I charge for the session, because nobody else could have had that time.

14

Voice by context – email, social media, print

Shorter forms, where there is room for one idea.

Basis: recommendation · email examples use placeholders and must be completed with confirmed facts

Email · replying to an enquiry

Four to six sentences. Answer what they asked first. Confirm the facts. Offer one next step. Lower the cost of taking it. First name only.

Thanks for writing. *[Answer to anything they asked.]*

Sessions are *[fee]* for *[length]* minutes, and I have *[day/time]* available. If you'd like to go ahead, *[first step]*.

There's no need to decide now, or to explain anything more first.

Alexander

Email · when you aren't the right fit

Say so quickly and kindly, give the reason in one sentence, and point somewhere useful.

Thanks for writing, and for being clear about what you're after.

From what you describe, a more structured approach might suit you better than the kind of counselling I offer. *[A specific pointer.]*

If I've misread it, tell me.

Alexander

Email · when you're full

Say it in the first line. Never “unfortunately”, never an apology paragraph.

I don't have a space at the moment. *[Waiting-list position, if you keep one.]*

[Directory] lists other counsellors near you, and you can filter by approach and fee.

Alexander

Social media – the recommendation is not to

No counselling social account at opening. It would be one more channel, it would put pressure on you to perform expertise, and it creates an awkward space for clients and former clients. It also sits too close to the studio's Instagram, which must never carry counselling content.

If you later want one: one idea per post; the repeat as the only template; no tips, no “signs you might be...”, no videos of you describing client work, disguised or not; no following or accepting clients.

A biography, if a platform needs one

Alexander Watson · *[place]* *[and online]*

Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why.

[Status line]

Print

A card carries the name, descriptor, position and how to get in touch. A leaflet carries all six messages in order across four sides, and nothing that is only true this month. Signs carry the name and “Counselling” – wayfinding is not messaging.

Two rules across every context

The first step is named as an action. “Write to me” or “arrange a call”, never a product. Not a discovery call, a consultation or a free session.

No channel ever pursues. No automated follow-ups, no “just checking in”, no reminder that a space is waiting.

15

Writing something new

A method for the things this guide couldn't predict.

Sooner or later something will need writing that this guide didn't foresee: a talk, a letter to another professional, a page about a change in how you work. This method keeps it in the same voice.

Basis: recommendation

- 01 **Write what you would say to one person, out loud.** Don't arrange it yet. The material is usually already there.
- 02 **Find the fact the reader needs first,** and put it first. What it is, who it's for, what it costs, when.
- 03 **Remove every feeling you assigned to the reader.** Replace each with a situation or a behaviour, or delete it.
- 04 **Find the verdict hiding in the draft** – a “should”, a “struggle”, a “finally” – and take it out.
- 05 **Name the limit.** What this new thing isn't, can't do, or doesn't know yet. Full size, first person.
- 06 **End on the reader's decision.** Then cut a third.

Then four tests

The retell test. Could a reader tell a friend what you work on, what you won't claim and what it costs?

The swap test. Put another counsellor's name on it. If nothing breaks, it isn't yours yet.

The verdict test. Does any sentence decide what the reader is, or what their behaviour says about them?

The bad-day test. Could someone with very little left read it once and know what to do next?

If someone else is writing it

Send pages 18 to 29 and nothing else. That is the complete verbal brief, and short enough to actually be read. Ask for the four tests to be applied before the draft comes back.

If a tool is writing it

Drafting tools reach for exactly the constructions on page 24. Give the tool pages 22 to 26, then read the result against the barred list line by line. Nothing drafted this way is published without that read.

16

The central visual idea

The repeat: the same thing, again, and noticed.

The visual identity rests on a single device, and the device is the practice's own idea made visible. It is made entirely of type; there is nothing to draw.

Basis: recommendation, derived only after Parts One and Two were settled

- 1 I'll sort it properly next week.
- 2 I'll sort it properly next week.
- 3 I'll sort it properly next week.
- 4 I'll sort it properly next week.

An ordinary sentence, set down several times, identically, with the count kept in the margin. The last instance is marked with the attention colour. Nothing explains it. Anyone who reads it knows what it means, and a reader who recognises the sentence has recognised themselves without being told.

It says four things without words: **this keeps happening** (the repetition); **it has been noticed, without judgement** (the count is a count, not a score); **attention is the intervention** (the mark); and **the meaning is yours** (none is supplied).

Everything else in Part Three follows. One typeface, because the repeat only works if the lines are visibly identical. A mostly ink-on-paper palette, so one colour can mean attention. Numerals as the only numbering. Nothing ornamental, because ornament would compete with the one thing being noticed.

What it carries

- Repetition, without a verdict
- Noticing as the act that matters
- Meaning left with the reader
- Plainness as respect

What it avoids

- Anything that illustrates therapy
- Two-part or paired marks
- Loops, arrows and process diagrams
- Breaking, fixing or completing the sequence

Readable on a bad day.

The design principle · the sentence to settle an argument with · from “capacity is not character”

16

The visual idea – what else was considered

Eight directions, and why each lost.

You listed several territories to explore. Each was tried against two tests: does it survive without explanation, and does it say something this practice believes?

Basis: recommendation

Direction	Why it wasn't chosen
Gaps and interruption	A pattern with a break in it says the job is to break the pattern. That is fixing, and it promises an outcome.
Two incompatible things in one space	Paired and two-part marks are the studio's most repeated device; Sofia Marin already owns "two readings of the same object".
Layers	Peeling back to a truer self underneath – the belief this practice explicitly doesn't hold.
Something obscured becoming legible	Casts the counsellor as the one who reveals. Interpretation as authority.
Movement between states	Needs a diagram to work, and diagrams of inner states become therapy illustration immediately.
Tension without resolution	True to the practice and invisible on a business card. It needed explaining every time.
Alignment and misalignment	Reads as a design error at small sizes, and implies a correct alignment to return to.
Green, amber, red	Your capacity model shaped the design principle, and stays private. As a visual it would be literal, would disclose a personal tool, would fail colour-blind readers, and would put a traffic light on a counselling practice.

Why the repeat survives without explanation

It uses a convention everyone already reads: a line written again is a line that happened again. There is no symbol to learn. It works at the size of a leaflet cover and the size of a phone screen, and it can be set by anyone with the typeface and the attention colour.

Where it could go wrong

Overuse. Once per surface is a signature; twice is a gimmick; on every page it becomes wallpaper. And sentence choice – a repeated sentence that names a feeling ("I feel like a failure") turns the device into exactly the mind-reading the practice refuses.

Test applied to every visual element in Part Three: if it were removed, would the repeat, the design principle or the practice lose anything? Three candidates failed and were removed – a monospaced typeface for the repeat (identical lines align in any typeface), the submark as a decorative footer mark (it belongs to the studio), and a second accent colour for links (links are underlined ink).

17

Logo system

Your artwork, as supplied. Four configurations, and no fifth.

The name is the supplied, drawn wordmark – never redrawn, respaced or retyped. The practice adds one typeset element beside it – the descriptor, with the place in the horizontal version – in the practice's typeface. Each configuration exists because a real application needs it.

Basis: established (the artwork) · recommendation (the system)



Stacked lockup · the primary

The artwork with “Counselling” centred beneath. Covers, cards, the leaflet, the top of a letter, a profile header. Anywhere the identity is the main thing on the surface.

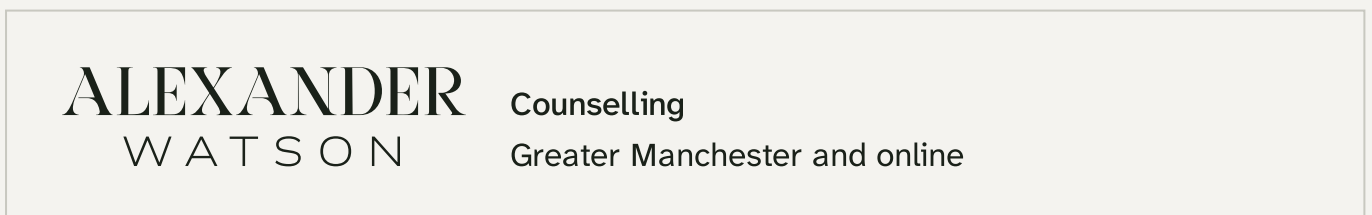
alexander-watson-counselling-stacked.svg · -reversed.svg · -black.svg



Stacked lockup, reversed

Paper on Ink. The same file, one colour change. Used on the one dark surface a piece is allowed.

Paper, and black for one-colour print, are the only colour changes the artwork receives.



Horizontal lockup

Artwork left; the descriptor and the place to the right, sitting on the artwork's own two baselines. Website header on wide screens, letterhead, email signature, a directory banner. A one-line version without the place is used where the place is already stated nearby.

alexander-watson-counselling-horizontal.svg · alexander-watson-counselling-horizontal-short.svg · reversed and black versions of each



Wordmark alone

No descriptor. Only where “Counselling” is already on the same surface.



Small use · the A

Favicon, app icon, a profile picture under 110 px. Never placed beside the wordmark, never used as ornament.

17

Logo system – the practice and the studio

The same name artwork does two jobs. It needs a clear division, or the practice looks like a sub-brand.

The artwork you supplied is the artwork on the studio website: the version with flanking rules in its header and footer, the A beside it, and the primary in its structured data. Using it here is right – it is your name – and it carries a risk this page manages.

Basis: established (studio usage, checked in the site files) · recommendation (the division)

ALEXANDER — WATSON — Alexander Watson Studio · forest and sage, Newsreader and Instrument Sans, editorial serif layouts	ALEXANDER Counselling WATSON Alexander Watson · Counselling · Ink, Paper and Attention, Atkinson Hyperlegible Next, plain left-aligned layouts
The studio keeps The alternate artwork with flanking rules. The A as a mark beside the name. Its palette, its typefaces, its editorial photography.	The practice takes The primary artwork only, always with the typeset descriptor unless “Counselling” is on the same surface. The A only as an icon. Nothing else visual is shared.
	Shared, deliberately Different, deliberately
Mark	The name artwork and its ink, #1A2119 Configuration: primary + descriptor here; alternate + A at the studio
Type	Open-licence, self-hosted fonts One sans here; a serif-led pair at the studio
Colour	Restraint: mostly paper and ink No forest, no sage here; no attention yellow at the studio
Layout	Left alignment, hairlines, no cards, generous space No editorial magazine spreads, no serif display headings here
Words	Plain British English, no clichés, no false claims This practice never offers or shows design work, and never addresses therapists

Links between the two The studio may link to the practice. The practice doesn’t link to the studio. One plain sentence in About may mention your design work (<i>your decision</i>).	The case-study problem The studio currently presents “Alexander Watson Counselling” as its own practice. Once the practice has clients, a client researching you would find their counsellor’s practice analysed as a studio case study. Recommended: retire it from the studio before opening, or present it very plainly.	The register question The artwork is elegant – high-contrast capitals, widely spaced. The practice’s voice is plain. The system handles this by spending polish in exactly one place, the name, and nowhere else. Page 59 is honest about whether that is enough.
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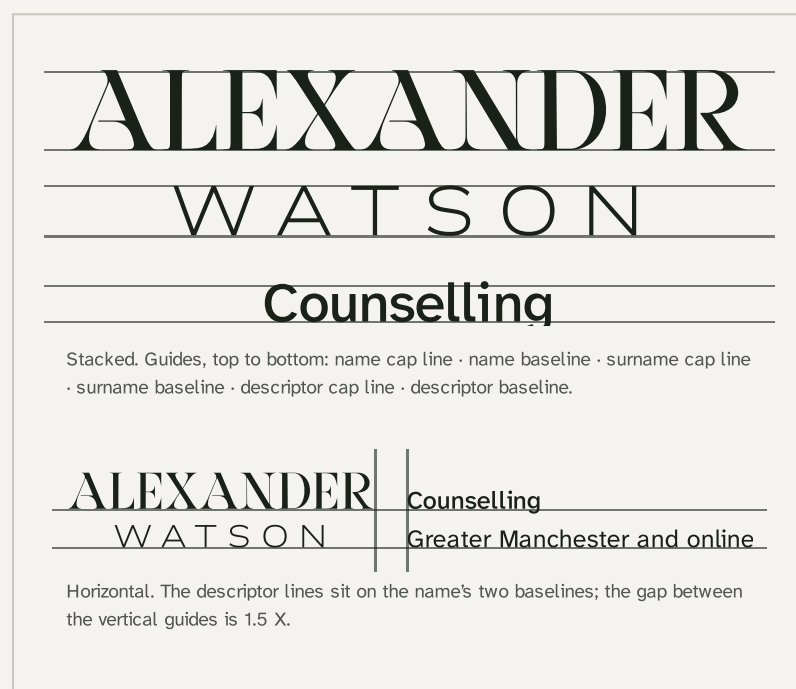
18

Logo construction

Measured from the artwork, so the lockups can be rebuilt exactly.

The artwork is fixed. These measurements describe how the descriptor is placed against it. All values are in the artwork's own units, where the supplied file is 2000 wide.

Basis: measured from alexander-watson-primary-logo.svg · recommendation (placement)



The unit

X = the surname's cap height = 144. Every placement is a multiple of X.

Name cap height	233
Surname cap height (X)	144 · 0.618 of the name
Gap, name to surname	105
Artwork ink width	1972
Surname stroke	12.5 · 8.7% of X
Descriptor cap height	108 · 0.75 X
Descriptor type size	161.7 · cap ratio 0.668
Descriptor weight	Medium 500, sentence case, no tracking

Stacked

Descriptor centred on the artwork. Its cap line sits **1 X** below the surname baseline. It is never tracked to match WATSON – spaced capitals would turn the lockup into the category's luxury formula.

Horizontal

Descriptor block starts **1.5 X** right of the artwork. "Counselling" sits on the name's baseline; the place sits on the surname's baseline. The two type systems share lines rather than sizes.

Clear space

1 X on every side of any configuration – 7.2% of the artwork's width. No text, rule, image edge or fold enters it. The A takes a quarter of its own height.

Minimum sizes, measured rather than guessed

Configuration	In print	On screen	Below that
Wordmark alone	30 mm wide	140 px wide	The name's hairlines break up. Use the A.
Stacked lockup	35 mm wide	160 px wide	The descriptor falls under 13 px. Use the wordmark, with "Counselling" as ordinary text nearby.
Horizontal lockup	75 mm wide	380 px wide	Use the short version, then the stacked lockup.
The A	5 mm	16 px	Nothing smaller exists.

Colour, in order of preference: Ink on Paper · Paper on Ink · black on white for one-colour print. The artwork is never set in Graphite, Attention or any tint.

19

Logo misuse

Eight things not to do to it.

None of these is a matter of taste. Each breaks a rule on the previous two pages, and the reason is given. Several are things the category does by default.

Basis: recommendation



Stretched

The proportions are the drawing.



Recoloured

Attention marks what is being noticed. It never colours the name.



The studio's version

The flanking-rule artwork belongs to the studio.



Tracked capitals

Echoing WATSON produces the boutique formula.



Status in the lockup

Credentials change and are checked. They live in the status line, never here. (The letters shown are placeholders.)



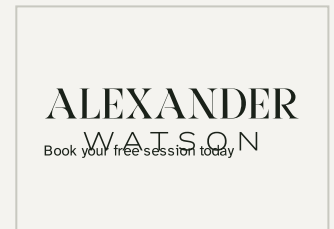
The A beside the name

That combination is the studio's footer.



On a gradient or photograph

The hairlines disappear. Flat Paper or Ink only.



Crowded

One X of clear space, and nothing sold inside it.

Also never

Outlined, shadowed, embossed or foiled · set below full opacity · rotated · used as a pattern or watermark · animated · retyped in any font · respaced · given a tagline inside the lockup · placed inside a circle or a box · combined with a professional body's logo inside the clear space. If an application seems to need one of these, the application is wrong.

20 Colour system

Mostly ink on paper, so that one colour can mean attention.

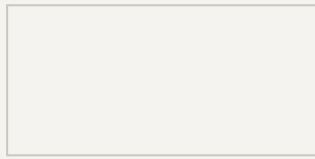
Nine values, named by job rather than by mood. Two of them do almost all the work.

Basis: recommendation · Ink is taken from your supplied artwork



Ink · #1A2119

All primary text. The artwork. The one dark ground per surface. Links, underlined.



Paper · #F4F3EF

The ground for everything read on screen. On print, the stock plays this part.



Attention · #E9E34A

Where attention is: the noticed line, keyboard focus, the current page, text selection, a form error. Nothing else.



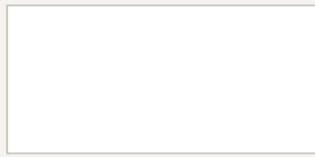
Graphite · #51564F

The second voice on light grounds: the count, labels, captions, hints, placeholders marked to confirm.



Recess · #E8E7E1

One quieter band per surface – the plain answers, or a quoted example.



White · #FFFFFF

Form fields, so they read as places to type. Never a page ground.



Rule · #C8C8C0

Hairlines on light grounds. Never text.



Mist · #A6ABA4

The second voice on Ink.



Rule on Ink · #3A423A

Hairlines on Ink. Never text.

Why this attention colour

It had to mean *look here* without meaning *wrong*. Red was ruled out first: it is the colour of a mistake being marked, and this practice exists to stop people reading their patterns as mistakes. Blue is the studio-portfolio's Daniel Mercer; orange, plum and rust are taken by other cases; green would sit beside the studio's forest and sage. A clear, slightly cool yellow is the colour of a highlighted line – something read and noticed – and it doubles as a focus colour that stands out on both grounds.

The rule that decides every new use

Attention appears only where someone's attention is being directed. If nothing is being noticed, it isn't there.

It is never a button fill, a background panel, a border, an icon colour or a decoration. It never carries text on Paper.

21

Dark and light behaviour

The same system on Ink. Nothing new is introduced.

Each value used on Paper has one counterpart on Ink. Attention stays the same colour on both grounds, which is the reason it was chosen at this lightness.

Basis: recommendation

On Paper

It keeps happening anyway.

Graphite for the second voice.

1 I'm fine, it's just a busy time.

2 I'm fine, it's just a busy time.

Fees and practicalities

Write to me

Write to me · focused

On Ink

It keeps happening anyway.

Mist for the second voice.

1 I'm fine, it's just a busy time.

2 I'm fine, it's just a busy time.

Fees and practicalities

Write to me

Write to me · focused

Job	On Paper	On Ink	Why
Primary text, artwork	Ink	Paper	A straight inversion; both measure 14.83:1.
Second voice	Graphite	Mist	Graphite disappears on Ink.
Hairlines	Rule	Rule on Ink	Each sits just far enough from its ground to separate without being noticed.
Attention	Attention, as a field under Ink text	Attention, as a field or as text	On Ink it is bright enough to carry text; on Paper it is not.
Focus ring	Attention fill, Ink outline	Attention fill, Paper outline	The outline carries the 3:1 contrast; the fill makes it unmistakable.
Main button	Ink fill, Paper text	Paper fill, Ink text	Actions are ink-weight, not coloured. Attention is reserved for focus.

- One dark surface per piece
- A dark ground is a statement. The website uses Ink for the footer only; the leaflet for its back page; the card for its reverse.
- Dark mode on the web
- Not offered at launch. If added later, it is this table applied whole – no new values.
- What is never added
- A tint of Attention. A second accent. A cream or beige. A green. Anything picked from a photograph. The list is closed.

22

Colour specifications

The numbers a supplier will ask for.

Contrast ratios are calculated from the hex values by the build that produced this document, not typed in. The CMYK column is arithmetic from the hex value rather than a press reading, so printers should work from the hex and send a proof.

Basis: recommendation · figures computed

Specifications				Contrast, measured against the painted ground		
Name	Hex	RGB	CMYK (conversion)	Pairing	Ratio	Use
Ink	#1A2119	26 33 25	21 0 24 87	Ink on Paper	14.83:1	Any text
Paper	#F4F3EF	244 243 239	0 0 2 4	Ink on White	16.46:1	Form input
Attention	#E9E34A	233 227 74	0 3 68 9	Ink on Recess	13.29:1	Any text
Graphite	#51564F	81 86 79	6 0 8 66	Ink on Attention	12.19:1	The noticed line; focus
Recess	#E8E7E1	232 231 225	0 0 3 9	Graphite on Paper	6.77:1	Secondary text
White	#FFFFFF	255 255 255	0 0 0 0	Graphite on Recess	6.07:1	Secondary text
Rule	#C8C8C0	200 200 192	0 0 4 22	Paper on Ink	14.83:1	Any text
Mist	#A6ABA4	166 171 164	3 0 4 33	Mist on Ink	7.04:1	Secondary text
Rule on Ink	#3A423A	58 66 58	12 0 12 74	Attention on Ink	12.19:1	Text, on Ink only
				Attention on Paper	1.22:1	Never text; never a focus indicator alone
				Rule on Paper	1.52:1	Hairline only
				Rule on Ink, on Ink	1.58:1	Hairline only

Reading the table

WCAG asks for 4.5:1 for body text and 3:1 for large text and for the parts of a control; 7:1 is the enhanced level. Every text pairing permitted here clears 4.5:1 and all primary text clears 7:1. Attention on Paper is listed so nobody is tempted: at 1.22:1 it can't carry text, which is why the focus state always adds an Ink outline.

Printing

Print on a bright, uncoated white stock and let it stand in for Paper – don't print a Paper tint across the sheet. Attention is a light, clean yellow that drifts green or orange on some presses: ask for a proof, and if a spot colour is needed, record the chosen match on page 57. Ink prints as a near-black; on uncoated stock ask for a slightly lighter ink film rather than changing the colour.

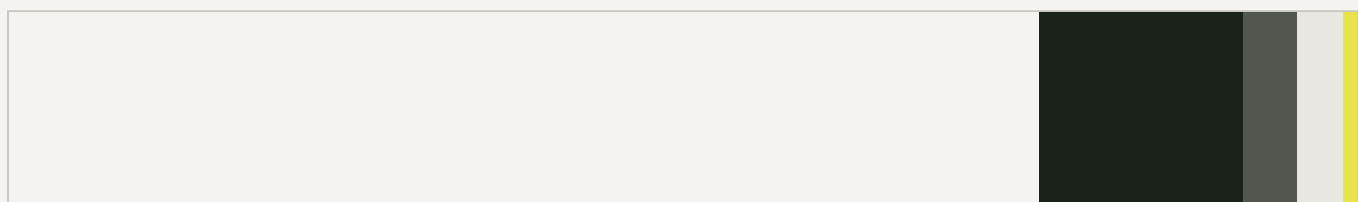
23

Colour proportions

Almost all paper and ink. That is the point.

These proportions hold on a screen, a leaflet, a card and a sign. They are the reason Attention works: a colour spent everywhere stops meaning anything.

Basis: recommendation



Paper 76 · Ink 15 · Graphite 4 · Recess 3.4 · Attention 1 · Rules and the rest 0.6

Pairings that work

- Ink on Paper – the default, and most of everything.
- Paper on Ink – one statement or one footer per surface.
- Ink on Attention – the one noticed line, or a focused control.
- Ink on Recess – the plain answers, set apart without a box.
- Graphite beside Ink – the count beside the repeated line.

Pairings that don't

- Attention on Paper as text, a line or a border.
- Attention beside Recess – two quiet fields muddy each other.
- Two noticed lines on one surface. Focus moves, so it doesn't count; a second marked line does.
- Two dark grounds meeting. Separate them with Paper.
- Graphite on Ink. Use Mist.

A rule for anything new

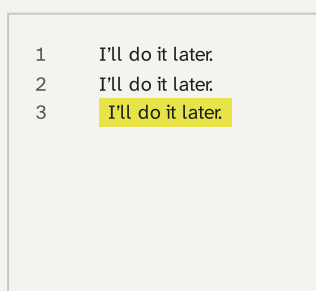
If a new element seems to need a colour, name which of the nine jobs it is doing. If it isn't doing one of them, it doesn't need a colour – it needs a hairline, or more space.

Where the one per cent goes

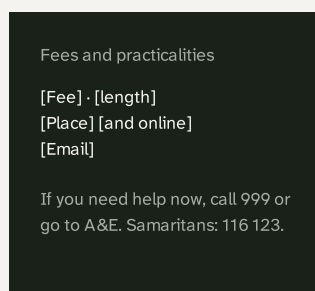
On the website home page: the last line of the repeat, and whatever currently has keyboard focus. On a leaflet: one line inside. On a card: nowhere.



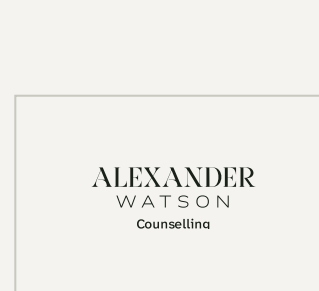
Leaflet cover · no Attention



Leaflet inside · one Attention line



Leaflet back · the one dark surface



Card front · Paper stock, Ink only

24

Typography

One typeface, chosen for the reader with the least left.

Atkinson Hyperlegible Next, and nothing else. The name artwork is the only other letterform in the identity, and it is a drawing, not a font.

Basis: recommendation

Aa

Atkinson Hyperlegible Next

Braille Institute · SIL Open Font License 1.1

I l 1 0 O r n m

Letters that are easily confused in other typefaces are drawn to be distinct.

Light 300 – the count: 1 2 3 4

Regular 400 – everything read at length

Medium 500 – headings, statements, the descriptor

Semibold 600 – labels and table heads

Italic 400 – only for words said aloud or quoted

Why this typeface

- **The design principle.** It was drawn for readers with low vision, so letters that blur into each other elsewhere stay distinct. “Readable on a bad day” asks exactly this of a typeface.
- **The first person.** Its capital I carries small serifs, so it can’t be mistaken for l or 1 – useful in a practice that writes “I” in most sentences.
- **One voice.** Sofia’s identity splits meaning and facts into two families. This practice treats the ordinary and the meaningful as the same material, so there is one family.
- **Distance from the name.** A plain sans beside an elegant drawn name keeps the name as the only ornament.
- **Distance from the studio.** No Newsreader, no Instrument Sans, no serif headings.
- **Practical.** Open licence, weights 200–800 with italics, tabular figures, on Google Fonts.

Not used

- A second typeface, anywhere
- Weights 200, 700 and 800
- Capitals for labels or headings, tracked or not
- Italic for emphasis
- Bold inside running prose on the website
- Centred text, except the stacked lockup and a card face

Its one weakness

It is less refined at display sizes than at reading sizes: the distinguishing details that help at 16 px can look busy at 60 px. Tighten large settings slightly (–1% to –2% tracking), use Medium rather than heavier weights, and keep headings short.

Figures

Proportional in running text. Tabular for the count, the plain answers, tables and times. The zero is slashed – keep it; it is part of the legibility.

One typeface. Hierarchy comes from size, weight and space, never from a second family.

The rule · it settles almost every typographic question

25

Typography hierarchy

Six roles, clearly apart.

Set as relationships to the body size, so the scale can be carried into any medium: fix the body size the surface needs, then multiply.

Basis: recommendation

Role	Setting	Step	Web · 18 px body	Specimen
Display	Medium 500 · leading 1.05 · –1.5%	× 2.6–3.4	46–60 px	It keeps happening.
Statement	Medium 500 · leading 1.25	× 1.35	24 px	What you do with it is yours.
Repeat	Regular 400 · leading 1.55 · count in Light 300, Graphite	× 1.2–1.8	22–32 px	1 I'll reply tomorrow.
Body	Regular 400 · leading 1.55	× 1	18 px	A lot of people can already explain a good deal about themselves.
Small	Regular 400 · leading 1.45 · Graphite where secondary	× 0.85	15–16 px	Replies within [time to confirm].
Label	Semibold 600 · sentence case · on a hairline	× 0.8	14–15 px	Fees and practicalities

Measure

Reading copy at 55–70 characters a line. Headings broken by hand where the sense breaks, never left to the browser at a width where one word is orphaned.

Space

One base unit and a scale built on it: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 6 · 8 · 12. The website uses 8 px; print uses 2 mm. When something looks wrong, try more space before another size, weight or colour.

Alignment

Left-aligned, ragged right, everywhere. Nothing justified. A single left edge per surface is the layout's version of plainness.

Minimum sizes

Website body	18 px, never below 16 px on any device
Website smallest text	14 px
Leaflet body	10.5 pt
Card, smallest line	7.5 pt
Signage	Descriptor cap height at least 15 mm at 3 m

Layout, in four rules

- **One thing per view.** Each screen or panel answers one question.
- **Grouped by space, not boxes.** No cards, no shadows, no rounded panels.
- **Hairlines separate; they never enclose.** One weight: 1 px on screen, 0.25 pt in print.
- **Dense and quiet alternate.** A practical block is followed by a short one.

Emphasis is made by position – its own line, its own space, or the attention field – and never by making text bold, italic, larger and coloured at once.

26

Typography substitutes

What to use when the real typeface isn't there.

Atkinson Hyperlegible Next is free and installable, so in most tools the answer is to use it. Where a tool won't, these keep the one thing that matters: a single, plain, very legible sans.

Basis: recommendation

First, use the real thing		If you can't	
Your computer	Install the desktop files from the typography folder. They appear in Word, Pages, Affinity and everything else.	First substitute	The original Atkinson Hyperlegible. Same designers, fewer weights.
Google Docs	Font menu, More fonts, search "Atkinson".	Then	Verdana. On every machine, wide and very legible. Set one step smaller.
Canva and similar	Search the font list; if Next isn't there, the original Atkinson Hyperlegible usually is. On a paid plan, upload the desktop files.	Then	Arial.
A developer	Give them the woff2 files and the licence. Self-hosted only: no font service, no third-party request, no reader's address sent anywhere.	In an email signature	Verdana, then Arial. Mail clients can't be relied on for more.
A printer or sign maker	Send the whole typography folder; the licence permits it. Or send outlined PDFs.	Never substitute with	
		Montserrat or any geometric sans – it competes with WATSON in the artwork. Playfair, Didot or any high-contrast serif – it competes with ALEXANDER. Any script, rounded or handwritten face. Times New Roman or Calibri, which make the practice look like a default.	

The rule to keep if everything else is lost

One plain sans. Left-aligned. Plenty of space. The name as the only ornament.

Why this survives bad tools

Someone working in a hurry, in a tool nobody chose, with Arial, can still produce something that belongs to this practice by keeping to one typeface, one left edge and the attention mark used once. A document in the right typeface that adds a second font, centres everything and puts facts in boxes will look wrong without anyone being able to say why.

27

Photography

Photographs that answer practical questions, and then stop.

For someone deciding with little capacity, uncertainty is the heaviest part. Photographs here reduce it: who is this, which door, what is the room like, what will I see on the screen. They inform; any mood comes from the real light in them.

Basis: recommendation · no photographs exist yet

The portrait

One, at eye level, at a normal conversational distance, looking at the camera. The expression is attention rather than performance: the face you make when someone has just said something worth hearing. No posed smile, no hand to chin, no arms folded, no laptop.

The places

The approach, the door, the room from where a client first stands, and – if you work online – what a client sees on their screen. Photographed as they are on an ordinary weekday, tidied no more than usual.

Light and treatment

Colour. Daylight, from one direction, with the shadows left in. A neutral grade: no cream, no green, no teal-and-orange, no film emulation. Square corners, no vignette, no filters.

Why colour

The identity is almost entirely ink and paper. Warmth is left to real things – wood, fabric, daylight – where it is true, rather than added through a warm palette where it would be a claim.

Placement

- A photograph sits in the column or at full width, never behind text.
- Nothing is set over an image, including the name.
- A photograph never sits beside the repeat; they would compete for the same attention.
- Every photograph has a caption or alt text that says what it shows, plainly: “The door on *[street]*. The bell is on the left.”

Real photographs only

The studio uses generated imagery for fictional practices, and that is right there. It is wrong here. A generated room, door or portrait of a real practice is a misrepresentation a client will discover on arrival. Until real photographs exist, the site uses none; the practice survives having no images far better than having false ones.

The test for any photograph

Would a first-time client, arriving, recognise this from the photograph – and did it answer something they needed to know?

If it only sets a mood, it doesn't belong.

28

Photography shot list

Six frames. The portrait always; the rest depend on where you work.

One shoot, one day, available light, by a photographer who is told the test on the previous page. Master sizes are the smallest files to keep; print sizes are what each will hold at 300 ppi.

Basis: recommendation · depends on location and online decisions, page 16

Frame	What it is for	Direction	Ratio	Master · print
01 The portrait always	So a visitor knows who they will be with.	Eye level, conversational distance, looking at the camera, daylight from a window. Everyday clothes you would work in. Choose the one you can live with for years.	4:5	1600 × 2000 135 × 169 mm
02 The approach if in person	So the building is recognised from the street.	From across the road or pavement, as someone arriving sees it. Enough of the street to place it. Nobody identifiable in frame.	3:2	2400 × 1600 203 × 135 mm
03 The door and access if in person	Which door, which bell, how many steps.	Close enough to read the bell or plaque. Include any steps or stairs honestly. For someone anxious about arriving, this is the frame that matters most.	4:5	1600 × 2000 135 × 169 mm
04 The room from the door if in person	So the first visit has already happened once.	From where a client stands on arrival. Both chairs as they really are. No props, no plants brought in, no tissues arranged.	3:2	2400 × 1600 203 × 135 mm
05 The online view if online	What a client will see on their screen.	A real screen capture or photograph of your actual set-up from the client's side: you, the wall behind you, the light. Consent and privacy settled first.	16:9	1920 × 1080 163 × 91 mm
06 One ordinary detail optional	The only frame allowed to be quiet.	Something genuinely there and unremarkable: the clock both of you can see, the window. Close, plain, unposed. Leave it out if nothing true suggests itself.	1:1	1600 × 1600 135 × 135 mm

Never photographed

Hands holding mugs · empty chairs as symbols · tissue boxes · candles, plants or cushions arranged for the shot · pebbles, beaches, forests, paths, sunsets, the sea · you mid-laugh or mid-gesture · you writing notes on a client · another person standing in for a client · a notebook on a knee · a laptop and a coffee · your design work, desk or studio · Stockport's viaduct or any landmark · anything generated or taken from a stock library.

Before the shoot

- Permission from the building owner and any other tenants who might appear.
- Nothing in the room that belongs to or identifies a client.
- Keep the original full-size files; a printer will ask for them.
- File names: alexander-watson-counselling-portrait.jpg, -approach.jpg, -door.jpg, -room.jpg, -online.jpg, -detail.jpg.
- If the room changes, reshoot 03 and 04 together rather than mixing two days.

29

Supporting visual language

Six behaviours. No icons, no pattern, no ornament.

There is no illustration, texture, icon set or graphic motif, because none of them would do a job. What exists instead are six ways of arranging a surface. Nothing in them belongs only to a screen.

Basis: recommendation

- 1 I'll do it later.
- 2 I'll do it later.
- 3 I'll do it later.

The repeat

The signature. Once per surface at most; many surfaces have none.

- 01 Write a short message.
- 02 I reply within *[time]*.
- 03 We arrange a first session.

The count

The only numbering: steps, sections, repeats. Two digits for sections, one for repeats. Never a score, a rating or a progress bar.

Most of it is ordinary. It keeps happening anyway. That isn't a failure of effort.

The attention field

A flat band of Attention behind one line. Line-height tall, square ends, never a hand-drawn swipe.

What does it cost?	[£-] for [-] min
Where?	[Place] [and online]
When will you reply?	[-]

The plain answers

Facts as the reader's own questions, each answered in one line, on Recess. Never cards, never icons.

Not everything is a pattern.

The statement

One sentence on Ink, with room around it. One per surface, and it states rather than explains.

One question, answered.

Space and hairlines

One thing per view. Hairlines separate and never enclose. Where something needs grouping, it gets space.

Instead of icons

Words. "Email", "Telephone", "Map", "Step-free: no". An icon is one more thing to decode for someone with little left, and the category's icons – leaves, hearts, speech bubbles, hands – are exactly the shorthand this identity avoids.

Links and actions

Links are Ink, underlined, always. Main actions are an Ink field with Paper text, square corners, sentence case: "Write to me". Secondary actions are underlined text. There is one main action per view.

29

Motion, interaction and accessibility

One movement in the whole identity, and an accessibility standard written as part of the design.

Basis: recommendation

The one movement

When the repeat first comes into view, the attention field draws across the last line, left to right, once, in about half a second. It is the act of noticing, performed a single time. It never loops, never replays on scroll, and with reduced motion switched on the field is simply there.

Everything else is instant

- Hover: the underline thickens. No colour change, no fade.
- Focus: Attention fill with a 2 px Ink outline – or Paper outline on Ink.
- No fade-ins, parallax, carousels, sliding panels, auto-playing video, pop-ups or loading animations.

Forms and errors

Labels above fields, always visible. Hints in Graphite below the label. Only name and a way to reply are required. An error is written in words beside the field, on an Attention field, and the field gains a 2 px Ink outline. No red: an error is something to look at, which is what Attention already means.

Accessibility, specifically

Standard	WCAG 2.2 AA as the floor, checked against the real painted grounds; AAA contrast for all body text.
Keyboard	Everything operable; focus always visible and never hidden behind a sticky header.
Targets	At least 44 × 44 px for anything tapped.
Colour	Nothing conveyed by colour alone. Attention always accompanies words or an outline.
Motion	prefers-reduced-motion honoured; nothing essential moves.
Reading	Plain language, short sentences, headings that say what follows. No PDFs for essential information.
Zoom	Usable at 400% and at 320 px wide with no sideways scrolling.
Structure	Real headings, landmarks and a skip link. The repeat is marked so screen readers read the sentence once with its count, rather than line by line.
Contact	Email and a form, and telephone if you want calls. No route requires speaking or typing a reason.
Time	No time limits, no session expiry on the form.
Urgent help	A link on every page, text-only, with numbers checked at every review.

The cognitive part

Readable on a bad day means more than contrast. From any page, in one step, someone should be able to find: what it costs, where it is, how to get in touch, and what to do if they need help now. That is the accessibility test this practice sets itself, and it is stricter than the standard.

30

Designing for this practice

The brief, before a medium is chosen.

This page holds whatever is being made – a website, a leaflet, a directory profile, a sign, something nobody has thought of. A designer who has never met you should be able to work from this page and Parts One to Three.

Basis: recommendation

What the practice established	What any implementation must therefore do
Recognition has to happen without a diagnosis.	Name no condition and no client type. Use ordinary situations and sentences people actually say, several of them, and include the simply hard alongside the repeating. The repeat, at most once.
This reader inspects before deciding.	Put what it is, where, what it costs and how to start before anything is asked of the reader, in numerals. Gate nothing behind contact.
Readable on a bad day.	One thing per view. Short sentences. From anywhere, one step to the fee, the place, how to get in touch and urgent help.
The decision stays with the person.	No instructions about the reader's life. A small, reversible first step. No urgency, no scarcity, no pursuit.
Understanding isn't the same as change.	Promise no outcome. Speak to people who already understand without making insight the price of entry.
The name is the only ornament.	Supplied artwork, one typeface, ink on paper, Attention once. No icons, illustrations, textures, cards, gradients or stock images.
Status will change.	Keep the status line in one place, exactly worded, never inside the lockup or the position.
A limit is content.	Anything inconvenient or chargeable is stated at full size, in the first person, before it can be discovered. Urgent-help signposting sits wherever someone might rely on the practice for it.

Decided by the medium, not here

Format, sequence, navigation, how many of the six messages appear, whether there is an image at all, and every mechanical decision that follows from the surface. This page fixes what must be true, not how.

Never, in any medium

A condition list. A feeling assigned to the reader. A promise about outcome. A limit in small print. A status the practice doesn't hold. A colour, typeface or component that isn't in Part Three. The studio's artwork configuration.

The test for anything made

Could someone who has never met you finish it able to say what you work on, what you won't claim, what it costs and how to start – and could they do that on a bad day?

The website follows as one implementation, because a worked example is easier to argue with than a principle. The identity is not derived from it.

31

Website – the architecture

Four pages to read, two to rely on, and nothing that makes someone click to find a fee.

Small on purpose, and set by what a prospective client needs to inspect rather than by the usual therapist template. Contact sits inside the practicalities page, so nobody writes before seeing the terms.

Basis: recommendation · for the existing domain once confirmed; the current site there is superseded by this spec

Page	Address	Its one job	What is on it
Home	/	Let someone judge fit in under a minute, and read more if they want.	Everything in brief, in the order on page 21, with the full contact route at the end.
How I work	/how-i-work/	Describe what actually happens, so there are no surprises.	A session; what you notice and say; what doesn't happen; in person and online; how long people come (<i>to confirm</i>); the first session; confidentiality and its limits; no threshold.
About	/about/	Let someone decide whether they could talk to you.	The portrait; the three hundred words; training and status; memberships and supervision wording (<i>to confirm</i>).
Fees and practicalities	/practicalities/	Every fact, then the way in.	The plain answers; where and access; times; payment and cancellation; notes and data; complaints; ending; then Contact at #contact, with what happens next.
If you need help now	/urgent-help/	Point someone in crisis somewhere that can help today.	Text only. Emergency services, NHS 111, Samaritans, and a line saying this practice can't respond urgently. Numbers checked at every review.
Privacy	/privacy/	Say what happens to what someone sends.	Plain English first, then the formal notice (<i>ICO details to confirm</i>).

Left out, and why

A separate Contact page	Merged, so terms and form are read together. /contact/ redirects to #contact.
"Who I work with"	It becomes a condition list.
FAQ	Each answer belongs where the question arises.
Blog	Not at launch; revisit only if you are already writing.
Testimonials	Never.
Booking, newsletter, chat	Not at launch. Each makes the first step bigger than a message.

Navigation

The name, top left, links home. Then: How I work · About · Fees and practicalities · Contact. On a phone, the same four under a button labelled "Menu" – a word, not an icon.

Footer, on Ink

Wordmark alone · the status line · place · email · If you need help now · Privacy · "This is not an emergency service."

Built to

Static pages, fonts self-hosted, no third-party requests, no tracking and therefore no cookie banner, a form handler that stores data in the UK or EU (*to confirm*), everything readable with scripts off, and the accessibility standard on page 46.

31

Website – the home page and the way in

Seven views, each answering one question, and a form that asks for almost nothing.

Basis: recommendation · placeholder facts in brackets

ALEXANDER
WATSON

Counselling

Menu

Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why.

Who for?	[Adults]
Where?	[Place] [and online]
Cost?	[£–] for [–] min
Reply?	Within [–]

Write to me

[Fees and practicalities](#)

- I know exactly why I do this.
- I know exactly why I do this.
- I know exactly why I do this.

Knowing why isn't the same as being free of it.

The same argument, with different people. · Work that matters and doesn't get started. · Saying yes, again, to something that should have been a no. · Wanting closeness, and wanting to be left alone. · Caring for someone until there's not much left over. · A loss other people think should be over by now.

None of these is a category.

How I work. I say what I notice, and check it. What you do with it is yours.

About me. [Portrait] · [Status line]

[Plain answers]

01 Write · 02 I reply · 03 [First step]

Footer

- 01 **First view.** The short horizontal lockup; the position as the page heading; four plain answers – who for, where, cost, reply time; one action, “Write to me”; a text link to fees. On a phone, all of this fits before the first scroll. The status line sits under them.
- 02 **The repeat.** “I know exactly why I do this”, three times, counted, the last marked, with the one movement from page 46. Then one line: “Knowing why isn't the same as being free of it”
- 03 **Things people describe.** Six to eight situations with no owner, repeating and simply hard mixed together. Closing line: “None of these is a category. You don't need to find yourself here.”
- 04 **How I work, briefly.** Notice, say, check, hand back; then what doesn't happen. Link to the full page.
- 05 **Who I am.** The portrait when it exists, sixty words, the status line, a link to About.
- 06 **The plain answers,** on Recess, complete.
- 07 **Getting in touch.** Three counted steps, the no-threshold line, and the action. The only Ink surface is the footer.

The form, at /practicalities/#contact

What should I call you?	Required
Email	Required
Telephone	Optional. “Only if you'd like a call.”
Anything you'd like me to know	Optional. Hint: “A sentence is plenty. It doesn't need to be serious, and you don't need to explain it well.”
Button	“Send”
After sending	“Thanks. I'll reply within [time]. If you change your mind, you don't need to tell me.”

No “what brings you here”, no drop-down of issues, no date of birth, no marketing consent box, because nothing is sent but the reply. Beside the button: a link to urgent help.

32

Digital applications

Everywhere else the practice appears on a screen.

Each of these can be done once, by you, and then left alone. None needs a designer and none is a content strategy.

Basis: recommendation

Directory profiles

The rules on page 27. The portrait as the photograph. The position as the headline. The hundred words unchanged. Checkboxes kept few and true.

Profile pictures

Where a face is expected (directories, Google): the portrait, cropped square from the same frame. Where a mark is expected: the A, Ink on Paper, with a quarter of its height as margin.

Google Business Profile

Only if the address can be public; otherwise none. Photos: frames 02–04 only. Posts and offers switched off.

Video sessions

A real, plain wall and daylight – the frame on page 44. No branded or blurred virtual background: a branded backdrop is the practice performing, and a blur hides what a client is entitled to see.

Social media

None at opening. Page 28 gives the reasons and the rules if that changes.

Email signature

Alexander Watson

Counselling · [Place] [and online]

[Status line]

[\[website\]](#)

This inbox isn't checked out of hours. If you need help now:

[\[website\]/urgent-help](#)

Simple text and one link style, in Verdana where the mail client allows a font. No image of the logo: images are blocked by many mail clients and can carry tracking. Verdana, because mail clients rarely load web fonts.

Automatic replies

One, for leave: "I'm away until *[date]* and will reply after that. If you need help now, *[urgent-help link]*." No auto-reply to ordinary enquiries – a real reply within the stated time is the promise.

Documents sent as PDF

From the letterhead template: Paper stock, one typeface, hairlines, the horizontal lockup at the top. The first-session information sheet, if you use one, follows the practicalities page word for word.

Link-sharing image

1200 × 630, Paper ground, the stacked lockup left, the position beside it. No photograph, no repeat.

Don't let a platform's house style overwrite yours.

Every tool offers a rounded card, a bold heading, an icon and a suggested colour. Each makes an average post look acceptable, and each makes this practice look like every other.

33

Print and physical applications

Few pieces, specified well enough that any printer can make them.

Most of these won't be needed on day one. None may carry a fact that is only true this month – availability and waiting times stay off paper.

Basis: recommendation · templates listed on page 56 are still to be made

ALEXANDER
WATSON
Counselling

Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why.
[email]
[website]
[Status line]

Business card · 85 × 55 mm

Front: the stacked lockup, centred – one of only two centred things in the identity. Back: the position, email, website and status line. No telephone unless you want calls. No Attention: a card has nothing being noticed.

Piece	Size	Notes
Appointment card	85 × 55 mm	Front as the business card. Back ruled for a date and time, written by hand. The cancellation notice in one sentence.
Information leaflet	A5, four sides	Front: stacked lockup and position only. Inside: the repeat once; situations; how I work; what doesn't happen. Back, on Ink: the plain answers, how to get in touch, urgent help. For GP surgeries and community noticeboards, with permission – never at your placement organisation or among its clients.
Urgent-help card	A6	For a shared waiting area only. Text from the urgent-help page. The wordmark small at the foot. Reviewed with the website.
Letterhead	A4	Horizontal lockup top left; address block only if the address is public; status line in the footer.
Invoice	A4	Letterhead furniture; the fee with its session length; bank details added by you, never saved in the template.
Envelope or stamp	DL · 20 mm	Not needed. If ever made: wordmark alone, or the A, one colour.

Stock	Colour	Bleed and safety	Finish
Bright white uncoated. 350 gsm cards, 120 gsm letterhead, 170 gsm leaflet. Never gloss, laminated or cream.	Ink from the hex values, Attention proofed before any run. One-colour jobs: Ink, or black.	3 mm bleed; nothing important within 4 mm of the trim. Cards supplied at 91 × 61 mm.	Square corners. No foil, emboss, spot varnish or edge colour. The artwork's hairlines won't survive any of them.

34

Signage and the room

A sign has one job: confirming the right door.

Everything the practice has to say is said before anyone arrives; the sign only confirms the place. And the likeliest first room – rented by the hour in a shared building – may allow no sign at all, which is fine.

Basis: recommendation · depends on the room, page 16



Door plaque · 150 × 50 mm · only for a room that is yours

Door plaque	
Content	The stacked lockup. Nothing else.
Material	Painted or powder-coated metal, or engraved. Not acrylic, glass or brass.
Colour	Ink on Paper, or engraved into a neutral ground. One colour.
Fixing	Flush, square, at eye level. No stand-offs, no bevel.
Caution	The artwork's hairlines need a minimum plaque width of 150 mm and a maker who can hold fine detail. Ask for a sample.

At street level

On a shared tenant board: “Alexander Watson · Counselling”, in whatever type the building uses, with the floor. Don’t fight a building’s signage; a practice that overrides it looks less settled, not more.

Never on a sign

The position or any sentence. Qualifications or letters. A telephone number or website, unless there is nowhere else to find them. Attention. Illumination.

Written directions instead

What actually helps someone arriving for the first time is a sentence in the first reply: which door, which bell, how many stairs, where to wait. That sentence does the signage’s real job.

The room itself

The consulting room carries no trace of the identity. Branding in the room would pull attention towards the practice, and the hour belongs to the client. Online, the same applies to the screen.

35

Supplier brief

Six briefs, so nobody has to guess.

Send the pages and files named and nothing else – short packs get read. Page 47 goes to everyone; the rest is chosen per trade.

Basis: recommendation

Supplier	Send	Ask for	Watch for
Printer	Pages 47, 32–35, 38, 51 · logo PDFs · the template PDF	A proof. Bright white uncoated stock. Square corners. No finish.	Attention drifting green or orange; the name's hairlines filling in on soft stock.
Sign maker	Pages 47, 32–35, 52 · logo SVGs	A physical sample, matched to the hex value.	Hairlines thickened “to cut cleanly”, rounded corners, the descriptor re-set in another font.
Web developer	Pages 47, 36–41, 45–46, 48–49 · colour tokens · font files · logo SVGs	Self-hosted fonts, no third-party requests, AA verified on the real grounds, full keyboard use, content readable with scripts off.	A component library bringing radii and shadows; analytics or a font service added for convenience; the repeat read aloud line by line by screen readers.
Photographer	Pages 47, 43–44	Daylight, eye level, neutral grade, the originals, and the test on page 43 applied to every frame.	Posing, props, a “thoughtful” portrait, a warm grade, a shallow-focus mug.
Writer or editor	Pages 47, 18–29	The four tests on page 29 applied before the draft returns.	The constructions and barred words on page 24; a feeling assigned to the reader; any new claim of status.
Another designer	Pages 18–54; say that page 47 is the brief and 30, 36 and 40 decide the rest.	Work within the existing grammar. Anything new written into page 57 before it is used twice.	A second typeface, a second accent, an icon set, cards, the studio's flanking-rule artwork.

The sentence to put in the email

“Attached are the pages and files that cover this job. The decisions in them are settled. If you need something that isn't there, ask me and I'll add it to the guide.”

What it does

It tells the supplier the decisions are made, and invites them to improve the guide instead of working round it. Every answer you give a supplier that isn't already in here belongs on page 57.

What never goes to a supplier

Everything before page 18, and everything from page 58 on. Those pages are about you, and are for you.

36

Right and wrong

The same thing said two ways.

Nothing in the right-hand column is badly written. It is the category speaking instead of you.

Basis: recommendation

This	Not this
A lot of people can already explain a good deal about themselves. It keeps happening anyway.	Do you find yourself stuck in the same unhelpful patterns, no matter how hard you try?
It doesn't need to be serious, and you don't need to explain it well.	Reaching out takes courage. Whatever you're going through, you deserve support.
Caring for someone can be relentless.	Caring for a loved one can be a rewarding but challenging journey.
I say what I notice, and check it. What you do with it is yours.	Together we'll develop the tools and strategies to help you thrive.
[£-] for [-] minutes, paid by [method].	Investment: please enquire for current rates.
I don't offer a set programme. If that's what you're after, [pointer] is a better place to start.	My integrative approach is tailored to your unique needs.
Trainee counsellor · Level 4 Diploma in Therapeutic Counselling, Stockport College, completing 2027	Qualified counsellor specialising in anxiety, relationships and self-esteem.

And in layout

Cost? [£-]

Where? [Place]

Reply? [-]

Right. Plain answers to the reader's questions.

1 I'm fine, honestly.

2 I'm fine, honestly.

Right. The repeat, counted, marked once.

How I work

I say what I notice.

More about how I work

Right. Left edge, a link in Ink, underlined.

[Real photograph of the room, full column, no text over it]

Right. A photograph that answers a question.

○◇□

Wrong. Three rounded cards with icons.

I'm fine, honestly. You might be feeling exhausted.

Wrong. Three marks, and a feeling assigned.

HOW I WORK

I say what I notice.

Learn more

Wrong. Centred, capitals, a yellow pill button.

"Healing begins within"

Wrong. A mood image with a quotation over it.

37

Identity checks

Eight questions, twice a year.

Small inconsistencies pile up unnoticed: a borrowed colour, an unvetted phrase, a leaflet with an old fee. Check in January and July, and before anything is reprinted.

Basis: recommendation

- 01 **Are the facts still true, everywhere?** Fee, length, days, place, online, reply time, cancellation, access. A fact wrong in one place is worse than a fact missing.
- 02 **Is the status line identical in all six places, and still permitted?** Get this one wrong and the consequence is professional, not cosmetic.
- 03 **Do the urgent-help details still work?** Helpline numbers and links change. Check each one by hand.
- 04 **Has anything appeared that isn't in this guide?** A colour, a second font, an icon, a card, a stock image, a barred word. Anything added without being written on page 57 gets copied by the next person.
- 05 **Does it still sound like you?** Read the About page aloud. Rewrite any sentence you wouldn't say.
- 06 **Are the photographs still true?** Same room, same door, a portrait someone would recognise you from.
- 07 **Is the studio still separate?** No counselling content on studio channels. No design on the counselling site. The case-study decision on page 33 still honoured.
- 08 **Has the idea become a hammer?** Read the situations and the About page. If everything has turned into a pattern, restore what is simply hard.

Every place the fee is written

Website · home page	Website · practicalities
Directory profiles, every one	Forty and hundred-word descriptions
Leaflet · back page	Invoice template
Enquiry-reply template	First-session information sheet
Three-hundred-word description	

Change all nine on the same day. The session length changes with it.

The one test that matters most

Could someone who has never met you rebuild the practice's presence correctly from this guide and its folder alone?

Yes, while the guide describes what actually exists. That is why page 57 matters more than it looks.

38

Asset register

What exists, what has to be made, and what this guide replaces.

Each line says its real state today, so the register never promises a file that doesn't exist.

Basis: established (supplied and existing) · recommendation (to make)

Folder	Contents	State today
START-HERE.md	One page: what this is, what to open first, who gets what.	<i>To make</i>
01-practice-identity-guide	This document as PDF, with its HTML source so it can be corrected without a designer.	Exists · version 1.0 draft
02-logo/supplied	alexander-watson-primary-logo.svg · Alexander-Watson-Alternate-logo.svg (studio only, kept for reference) · Alexander-Watson-Submark.svg	Supplied
02-logo/svg · png · pdf	Stacked, horizontal and short-horizontal lockups with the descriptor outlined; reversed and black versions; the A as a square tile.	<i>To make – built in the source of this guide, not yet exported as files</i>
03-colour	The nine values as plain text, CSS custom properties, JSON and a swatch file.	<i>To make – values fixed on page 38</i>
04-typography	Atkinson Hyperlegible Next: web files, desktop files, OFL licence.	Web files and licence exist in the guide's source; desktop files <i>to download</i>
05-templates	Business card, appointment card, leaflet, urgent-help card, letterhead, invoice, email signature, enquiry replies.	<i>To make</i>
06-website	Favicons and app icons from the A; link-sharing image; the specification on pages 48–49.	<i>Specification exists; files to make</i>
07-photography	Up to six frames and their originals.	<i>To commission, after the room is known</i>
08-for-suppliers	Six briefs from page 53, as text to forward.	<i>To make</i>
09-words	The position, four descriptions and directory texts as plain text.	<i>To make, once page 16 is filled</i>

Things this guide affects

alexanderwatsoncounselling.co.uk	Linked from the studio. The site there shares the studio's typefaces and predates this guide. Check what it says today. To be rebuilt to page 48 before opening.
Practice Clarity example, August 2026	Superseded by this guide.
Studio case-study presence	Decision on page 33.

File naming

alexander-watson-counselling-what-variant.text – lower case, hyphens, no spaces, no dates, no "final". The supplied artwork keeps its original names so it can be matched to the studio's copies.

Deliberately not here

No proprietary design files: SVG, PNG, PDF, HTML, plain text and an open font only, so nothing needs a subscription or one particular studio.

39

Rules for future changes

How to change something without losing the rest.

The practice will change, and an identity that can't change with it becomes something to work around. What matters is that each change is written down, so this guide keeps describing what exists.

Basis: recommendation

Four questions before adding anything

- 01 **What job does it do?** One sentence. If the sentence is about how it looks, leave it out.
- 02 **Can something existing do that job?** Usually: more space, a hairline, the plain answers, the count.
- 03 **Where exactly is it allowed?** One named place. Something allowed everywhere becomes a second identity within a year.
- 04 **Is it written down?** Below, and in the asset register.

Changes that need real thought

Qualifying, registering	The status line only, in the six places. Nothing visual changes.
A new room	Facts, frames 02–04, access text, signage.
Couples, families or young people	A decision about the practice first. The position holds; the descriptions say “adults” and would change.
Further training	Possibly the descriptor. Never the name artwork.
A specialism	Only with the training behind it. The position still holds; add it to the descriptions, not the headline.
Writing in public	The Inner Map and Embracing Authenticity are separate projects. Keep them separate from the practice.
A second practitioner	A name-based identity doesn't stretch. That is a new identity decision.
The studio changes its artwork	This practice shares the artwork, so it changes too. Decide together, deliberately.

Change log

Date	What changed	Why	Where allowed	Guide updated
September 2026	Version 1.0 draft issued for review	–	–	–

When the log has four or five entries, re-export this guide from its source with the changes written into the right pages, and raise the version number. Supplier colour matches go here too.

A

The five most important decisions

Everything else depends on these. Change one, and most of the guide moves with it.

01 The practice is organised around what keeps happening, and what it is doing.

Not around accuracy, noticing or plain speaking – those are how you work, and your portfolio has already spent them. “Nothing repeats for no reason”, with its limit, “not everything is a pattern”, written in from the start.

02 The reader is defined by their relationship to their own insight, not by their intelligence.

People who can see what keeps happening and for whom seeing hasn’t been enough, whatever their vocabulary – alongside people carrying something that is simply hard. Your supplied reader is kept as one of three, not as the definition.

03 No verdict and no reassurance in advance.

The voice says the plain true thing, including “that is hard”, describes behaviour instead of feelings, and hands every decision back. The load-bearing message is “I say what I notice; what you do with it is yours.”

04 Your name, your supplied artwork in its primary form, and “Counselling” – with status kept out of all three.

No invented practice name. The flanking-rule version and the A as ornament stay with the studio. The status line lives in one place and changes without touching the identity.

05 Designed to be readable on a bad day.

One typeface chosen for legibility, almost everything ink on paper, one attention colour with one job, and the repeat as the only signature. The website’s first view answers what, where, how much and how to start.

The chain

01 Idea: nothing repeats for no reason

02 Position: what keeps happening, even when you know why

03 Voice device: the repeat

04 Visual idea: the repeat, counted and marked

05 Design principle: readable on a bad day

06 One hyperlegible typeface, one attention colour

07 A first view that answers four questions

B

What I am least certain about

Six places where this could be wrong, and what would tell us.

Uncertainty	Why	What would settle it
The wordmark's register	The artwork is elegant: high-contrast capitals and a widely spaced surname, a style the category associates with boutique and personal brands. The practice's voice is plain and dry. The system confines polish to the name, but the name is the first thing anyone sees. I have used it as you asked; I am not sure it is the best face for this practice.	Show the stacked lockup and a plainly typeset "Alexander Watson" side by side to three people who fit the reader, and ask which one they would expect to be direct with them.
The shared artwork	Configuration, colour and type separate the practice from the studio, but anyone who knows the studio will see the same name drawn the same way. That is honest and it is also a sub-brand signal.	Your answer to question 02, and whether the studio keeps the counselling case study.
The attention yellow	It has a clear job and a reason, and it is the least conventional choice here. It could read as playful, or as a highlighter aesthetic that dates.	See it at full size on a phone, in the repeat and as a focus ring, before anything is printed. The fallback is to keep it for focus only.
The position's "even when you know why"	It is the hook for your supplied reader, and it may over-select the very intellectual audience page 11 argues against. The longer descriptions correct for it; the headline doesn't.	Real reactions from people like your placement clients, not from therapists or designers.
The central idea's weighting	"Nothing repeats for no reason" leans psychodynamic. Your training is equally person-centred, and the placement issues you describe – bereavement, responsibility – often call for company as much as interpretation.	Your own view, and your supervisor's, of whether it describes how you actually work.
One sans typeface	It serves legibility and plainness. It could feel institutional without the warmth a serif gives, and Atkinson's distinctive letters are an acquired taste at display sizes.	Set the home page's first view in it at real size. If it reads as a public-service form, tighten the display settings before changing the typeface.

What I am confident about

The challenge to the reader definition; keeping status out of the identity; the refusal to use generated imagery for a real practice; the website architecture; and the separation from the studio. Those would survive most of the answers to the questions overleaf.

C

Questions for Alexander

Only the questions whose answers change the identity.

Everything else on page 16 can stay a placeholder until you open. These can't, because the words and the visual system depend on them.

- 01 **Does “nothing repeats for no reason – and not everything is a pattern” describe how you actually work?**

If not, pages 05 to 30 change: the position, the repeat and the design principle all come from it.

- 02 **Are you content for the practice to share the studio's name artwork, separated by configuration – or would you rather the counselling practice set your name plainly in its own typeface and leave the drawn artwork to the studio?**

You asked for the supplied logos and I have used them. This is the question I would most want answered before anything is printed. It changes pages 32 to 35, the cover, and every application.

- 03 **Will the practice mostly be a rented room, mostly online, or both as equals – and roughly where?**

It changes the descriptor line, the photography, signage, the home page's first view and the forty and hundred-word descriptions.

- 04 **Should the counselling practice mention your design work at all, and will the studio stop presenting the practice as its own case study before you open?**

It changes the About page, the three hundred words and the separation rules on page 33.

- 05 **Are these true of how you intend to practise: no set programme or homework unless agreed; no follow-up if someone doesn't reply; and a first conversation before a first session (and if so, how long and whether free)?**

Each is written into the voice and the client experience as a trust signal. A trust signal that isn't policy is a false claim, so each needs a yes or a correction.

Not asked, deliberately. Fee, session length, hours, membership body, insurer, address. They are facts, not identity decisions; each has a place waiting on page 16.

D Creative direction summary

For a senior designer who won't read the rest.

Client	Alexander Watson – counselling for adults, <i>[place] [and online]</i> . In training until 2027: status is a separate fact line, never part of the identity.
Idea	Nothing repeats for no reason. What keeps happening is usually doing something, which is why understanding it often doesn't change it. Not everything is a pattern.
Position	Counselling for what keeps happening – even when you know why.
Reader	People who can see what keeps happening and for whom seeing hasn't been enough, whatever their vocabulary; and people carrying something simply hard. Wary of being handled, labelled, cheered on or told what they feel.
Experience	Recognition without diagnosis. Warmth without handling. Depth without mysticism. Professional without coldness. Direct without aggression. Structure without rigidity. Space without emptiness. Inspect fully before contact; a small, reversible first step.
Voice	Plain, dry, attentive. Behaviour, never feelings. The true sentence, then the decision handed back. Short sentences, British English, spaced en dashes, no exclamation marks.
Visual idea	The repeat: an ordinary sentence set three or four times, counted in the margin, the last marked with Attention. Once per surface at most.
Principle	Readable on a bad day. One thing per view; fee, place, contact and urgent help one step from anywhere.
Logo	Supplied primary artwork, never altered, with "Counselling" typeset in Atkinson Hyperlegible Next Medium, sentence case. Stacked, horizontal, wordmark alone, the A for icons. The flanking-rule version and the A as ornament belong to the studio.
Type	Atkinson Hyperlegible Next only. 300 for the count, 400 body, 500 headings, 600 labels. Sentence case everywhere. No second family.
Colour	Ink #1A2119 · Paper #F4F3EF · Attention #E9E34A (where attention is: the noticed line, focus, current page) · Graphite #51564F · Recess #E8E7E1 · White #FFFFFF · Rule #C8C8C0 · Mist #A6ABA4 · Rule on Ink #3A423A. Roughly 76% paper, 15% ink, 1% attention.
Layout	Left-aligned, hairlines that separate and never enclose, grouping by space, one Ink surface per piece, facts as plain answers to the reader's questions. Square corners.
Photography	Real, colour, daylight, eye level, neutral grade. Portrait, approach, door and access, room from the door, the online view. Evidence, not mood. Nothing generated.
Motion	One: the attention field draws across the last repeat, once. Everything else instant. Reduced motion honoured.
Never	Sage, beige, forest green, gradients, cards, icons, illustrations, leaves, pebbles, hands, mugs, paths, two-part marks, tracked capitals, a second typeface, testimonials, condition lists, "safe space", "journey", status claims, urgency.
Website	Home · How I work · About · Fees and practicalities (with contact) · Urgent help · Privacy. Static, self-hosted, no tracking, WCAG 2.2 AA with AAA body contrast.

If it could belong to another counsellor, or it needs explaining, it isn't finished.

Quality control

The eight tests you set, and how the identity did.

Run against the finished guide, not the intention. Where a test only partly passes, it says so.

Test	Result	Evidence, and what remains
1 • Swap	Passes	Put another counsellor's name on it and the central idea, position, repeat, design principle, typeface rationale, "not everything is a pattern" guard and the name artwork all stop working. What survives the swap is deliberate category hygiene: practical-information rules, accessibility, the barred-word list. The harder swap – against your own portfolio – failed on the first pass (accuracy was Sofia's, noticing was Helen's) and was fixed by changing the organising idea.
2 • Personality	Passes	Each of your twelve themes is traced on page 05; the capacity model became the design principle without being disclosed; the success-and-failure insight appears once in public copy without its source. The risk ran the other way: the supplied reader was partly a self-portrait, challenged on page 11.
3 • Client	Partly	The repeat lets a reader recognise a sentence without being told a feeling, and it works for the reader who can explain themselves and the one whose "should" outruns them. It does less for the carer or the bereaved reader, who is reached through the situations and the "not everything is a pattern" paragraph instead. Only real readers can confirm either.
4 • Ethics	Passes, with conditions	A search of the finished text finds "qualified", "accredited", "registered", "specialist", "expert" and "psychotherapist" only where they are barred or shown as wrong. No fee, address, hours, membership, insurance, supervision arrangement, years, outcome or testimonial is stated. The one example of letters after a name is marked as a placeholder. Conditions: check today what the existing counselling site says; urgent-help numbers are checked at publication; the placement is named only with permission; nothing offering sessions is published before you are permitted to practise.
5 • Restraint	Passes, one flag	Removed for having no job: a monospaced face, the A as ornament and a second accent (page 31). Icons and a separate symbol were never admitted. Nothing here is therapeutic-looking. The element present for polish rather than meaning is the drawn wordmark, which you specified (page 59).
6 • System	Passes	Every major decision has a line back to the idea: see the chain on page 58 and the brief on page 47. The weakest link is the yellow, which traces to the idea through "attention" rather than directly.
7 • Five years	Passes	The descriptor, position and idea don't depend on status, niche or location; status lives in one line. What will date: the portrait, possibly the yellow. What would break it: a second practitioner, or the studio changing its artwork.
8 • Alexander	Mostly	Recognisably the same person – the name, the restraint, the precision, the refusal to overclaim – and it never shows design work or sells to clients. The shared artwork means someone who knows the studio will see the connection immediately; the system manages that rather than removing it.

Quality control – the system traced

Every visual and verbal decision, and the line back to the idea.

Decision	Comes from	Would it matter if removed?
Position: “even when you know why”	Insight is rarely enough	Yes – it is the recognition
“Not everything is a pattern”	The idea’s limit; accuracy before reassurance	Yes – it keeps carers and the bereaved in the audience
Describe behaviour, never feelings	Autonomy; recognition without diagnosis	Yes – it is the reader’s main fear
The hand-back	The person is the authority	Yes – it answers “being handled”
The repeat	Nothing repeats for no reason	Yes – it is the idea, visible
The count in the margin	Noticing without a verdict	Yes – without it the repeat reads as a typo
Attention colour, one job	Noticing as the intervention	Yes – and it is the focus state
Mostly ink on paper	So attention can mean something; no warmth by adjective	Yes
One hyperlegible typeface	Capacity is not character; readable on a bad day	Yes
Sentence-case labels, no tracking	Plainness; distance from the artwork’s spaced surname	Yes – tracked labels make the boutique formula
Supplied artwork, primary only	Your name; separation from the studio	Yes – but see page 59
No icons	Readable on a bad day; no category shorthand	Adding them would cost
Evidence photography, nothing generated	Inspect before deciding; accuracy	Yes
One movement	Noticing, performed once	Only a little. It is the most removable element, and would be the first to go
Contact inside practicalities	Inspect before deciding	Yes
No pursuit, no urgency	Success and failure; decisions not made while depleted	Yes

Machine checks run on this document

Every hex value in the source matches the palette; every contrast ratio shown was calculated from those values; no page overruns its margin; every page reference resolves; the four descriptions measure 13, 39, 97 and 298 words.

Read it once. Then say what's wrong with it.

Mark anything factually wrong. Mark anything true that doesn't sound like you. Mark any recommendation you disagree with and say what you'd do instead – “not me” is enough to start.

After that round it becomes the practice's reference: what you check before writing, printing or briefing anyone.

It was built so that a printer, a sign maker, a photographer or a developer could each work from it without needing you in the room.

What to review first

- The central idea and its limit
- The challenge to the reader definition
- The five questions on page 60
- The position, the voice and the repeat
- The wordmark decision and the yellow
- Anything that says more about you than you want known

How to mark it up

In one go, rather than a page at a time. Consolidated notes produce a better second version.

ALEXANDER
WATSON
Counselling